



INTERNATIONAL OLYMPIC ACADEMY



Esports within Olympic Culture



15th

INTERNATIONAL SESSION
FOR EDUCATORS OF HIGHER INSTITUTES
OF PHYSICAL EDUCATION

ANCIENT OLYMPIA



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6–11 JULY 2025

Editor
KONSTANTINOS GEORGIADIS
Professor, University of the Peloponnese
Dean, International Olympic Academy

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FOREWORD

The International Olympic Academy, faithful to its mission as the leading international centre for the study, dissemination and promotion of Olympism, continues to serve as a unique meeting place for ideas, cultures and scholarly dialogue. At the IOA, knowledge meets history, and academic research is creatively connected with the contemporary challenges of sport, education and society.

The 15th International Session for Educators of Higher Institutes of Physical Education, held from 6 to 11 July 2025, confirmed once again that Olympism is not a static body of principles but a dynamic educational philosophy, capable of evolving alongside the changes of the modern world. The selection of the main subject, “The Future of Sport”, and the special subject, “Esports within the Framework of Olympic Culture”, reflects the need for the Olympic Movement to address creatively the technological developments that are transforming learning, sport participation and social relations.

The presentations and scientific discussions of the Session demonstrated that the rapid development of digital technology and artificial intelligence is not merely a technical challenge but, above all, an educational and ethical issue. Education is now called upon to prepare citizens who will not only be digitally literate but also capable of critical thinking, able to recognise the ethical dilemmas posed by technology, and committed to placing human beings, values and social responsibility at the centre of technological development.

Of particular importance was the common conclusion reached by the participants that Olympism possesses the theoretical and value-based foundation necessary to guide this transition. The principles of fair play, respect, excellence, friendship and peaceful coexistence can serve as enduring points of reference in an environment where technology evolves more rapidly than our social and ethical adaptations. The challenge is not to resist innovation but to integrate it into a framework that serves human development and democratic education.

This publication records not only the principal scientific conclusions of the Session but also the fruitful dialogue that developed among educators from 15 different countries. The diversity of cultural experiences and alternative educational approaches, and the exchange of good practices, once again demonstrated that multiculturalism constitutes one of the greatest strengths of the International Olympic Academy. International cooperation is not confined to the exchange of knowledge; it creates learning communities, cultivates relationships of mutual respect and strengthens the international dimension of Olympic education.

At the same time, the Session emphasised the decisive role of the educator as a bearer of values and leadership. At a time when information is immediately accessible but knowledge requires interpretation, the educator's role extends far beyond the transmission of information. The educator becomes a guide, an inspiration and a shaper of responsible citizens who are capable of combining scientific knowledge with ethical judgement and social awareness. Artificial intelligence may enhance the learning process, but it cannot replace human creativity, the pedagogical relationship or the educator's personal responsibility.

Equal emphasis was placed on the need to develop international collaborations, interdisciplinary research and digital networks for the exchange of educational resources. The proposals formulated during the Session go beyond theoretical considerations; they provide concrete directions for the further strengthening of Olympic education worldwide and for the creation of an international network of knowledge, cooperation and innovation.

The particularly positive evaluation of the programme by the participants confirms the high quality of its organisation, the academic excellence of the presentations and the significance of its thematic focus. At the same time, the constructive suggestions for even greater interactivity and for more practical applications in educational settings constitute valuable feedback that will contribute to the continuous enhancement of the future initiatives of the International Olympic Academy.

This publication aspires not only to serve as a record of the proceedings of the 15th Session but also as a reference work for all those engaged in Olympic education, sport pedagogy and the relationship between technology and humanism. At a time of profound social and technological transformation, Olympism continues to offer a timeless framework of values through which education can shape responsible citizens, creative leaders and societies founded upon respect for human dignity and cooperation among peoples.

The International Olympic Academy remains firmly committed to its mission of advancing this very synthesis of tradition and innovation, safeguarding the fundamental principles of Olympism while at the same time opening new pathways for education, research and international dialogue. This publication constitutes yet another testament to this ongoing endeavour and an invitation to further cooperation, reflection and creative action for the benefit of Olympic education and the global educational community.

Prof. Konstantinos GEORGIADIS
University of the Peloponnese
IOA Dean



Opening Ceremony

ANCIENT OLYMPIA, 7 JULY 2025

Excerpt from Pierre de Coubertin Writings

"It is not just internationalism and democracy, the foundations of the new human society now being constructed in civilized nations, but science as well that is involved in this sentiment. Through its constant progress, science has given man new ways to cultivate his body, to guide and strengthen nature, and to snatch the body from the constraints of unbridled passions to which it had become subject in the name of individual freedom."

"The philosophic foundation of modern Olympism", in *Le Sport Suisse*, vol. 31, August 7, 1935, p. 1 (*Pierre de Coubertin (1863-1937), Olympism, Selected Writings*, Norbert Müller (ed.), Lausanne, IOC, 2000, p. 580)



«Ce ne sont pas seulement l'Internationalisme et la Démocratie, assises de la nouvelle société humaine en voie d'édification chez les nations civilisées, c'est aussi la Science qui est intéressée en cela. Par ses progrès continus, elle a fourni à l'homme de nouveaux moyens de cultiver son corps, de guider, de redresser la nature, et d'arracher ce corps à l'étreinte de passions déréglées auxquelles, sous prétexte de liberté individuelle, on le laissait s'abandonner.»

«Les assises philosophiques de l'Olympisme moderne», dans *Le Sport Suisse*, vol. 31, 7 août 1935, p. 1.

The opinions of the lecturers do not necessarily reflect those of the International Olympic Academy. Out of respect for multiculturalism and diversity of scientific research, we do not intervene in each student's way of presenting his/her bibliography and footnotes.

ADDRESS AND OPENING
of the Session Proceedings
by the President of the International Olympic Academy
Prof. Charilaos TSOLAKIS

Dear Distinguished Guests and Participants,
Dear Colleagues,

As the newly appointed President of the International Olympic Academy (IOA), it is an immense honour to welcome you to Ancient Olympia – the cradle of Olympism, the birthplace of the Olympic Games, and the source of inspiration for Baron Pierre de Coubertin to revive these Games in modern times, heralding the dawn of modern Olympism. The IOA carries forward this rich legacy by embracing the moral and educational core of Olympism. Our location here in Ancient Olympia not only symbolises a connection to the origins of the modern Olympic Movement but also actively sustains and celebrates this heritage.

Since its establishment in 1961, the IOA has introduced a groundbreaking approach to both international Olympic studies and education. Today, the IOA provides a unique international platform for education, teaching, learning, and networking and is globally recognised as the leading centre for education in and through Olympism, shaping future generations of role models, leaders, and change-makers. We achieve this through experiential Olympic and sports educational programmes primarily targeting youth, but also extending to individuals, teams, and organisations inspired by the Olympics and the world of sports.

The IOA is at the forefront of redefining physical education by harmonising it with the rich heritage of Olympic values, offering a transformative approach to creating a better world. This new perspective elevates physical education from being merely supplementary to becoming a central component of holistic development. By utilising innovative methodologies, incorporating technology, and embracing a diverse range of sports and wellness practices,

physical education becomes a vital tool for instilling resilience, teamwork, and mental and physical well-being in young people. Furthermore, integrating Olympic values such as excellence, respect, and friendship into educational frameworks fosters a generation of mindful global citizens.

The 15th International Session for Educators of Higher Institutes of Physical Education is organised around the theme: “The Future of Sport”, with a special focus on “Esports within Olympic Culture”.

Dear Friends, in modern society, technology has been a critical factor in resolving many everyday challenges. Naturally, its evolution has significantly influenced sports, often in positive ways. Today, with advancements in artificial intelligence, it's impossible to address complex issues like performance and training analysis, athlete injury prevention and prediction, talent recruitment and detection, refereeing support, and real-time decision-making without AI, which is shaping the future of sports.

However, using technology to "assist sports" is distinct from using it to "replace sports". This topic has sparked philosophical debates among many contemporary scholars who strive to understand the essence of "sports" in light of the rise of esports—an accelerating trend among today's youth.

Daily, thousands of gamers aspire to reach the top. Rules, regulations, and ethics provide a foundation for fair play and smooth competition operations. Though relatively new, esports has established itself as a sector of global industry. Its origins can be traced back to the early 1970s, when the first electronic gaming tournament took place in the USA. However, it was during the early 2000s that esports truly flourished, driven by Internet proliferation and easy access. Games that once involved a few players now engage millions globally.

The rapid expansion of esports introduces several challenges, including debunking misconceptions and examining esports as a legitimate sport. In this context, discussions will focus on a) the future of esports and education, b) the integration of esports into educational systems, c) the economic and social impacts of esports, d) esports growth and community engagement, and e) the impact of esports events on an international scale.

Integrating esports into the global sports framework is fraught with challenges. Key concerns include: a) how to engage with the esports community to promote Olympic values and integrate esports into traditional

sports frameworks, and b) how to educate parents and decision-makers about the benefits and realities of esports.

Dear Participants, these topics will be thoroughly explored in your work over the coming days. I wish you a fruitful conference and hope you enjoy the breathtaking surroundings of Ancient Olympia, the outstanding facilities here, and the sun-soaked ambiance of my beloved country.

Thank you.



Proceedings



LECTURES

ANCIENT OLYMPIA, 7-10 JULY 2025





FRAMING OLYMPIC VALUES THROUGH RHETORICAL AND DATA-BASED PEDAGOGIES

Dr Andreas KARATSOLIS (GRE)

MIT Writing, Rhetoric and Professional Communication

Nicolas STONE-PEREZ

MIT Sports Lab

Annette (Peko) HOSOI

MIT Sports Lab

Abstract

This paper explores how rhetorical pedagogy, data analysis, and experiential learning can be combined to cultivate Olympic values in contemporary sports education. Drawing on examples from MIT's *Writing about Sports* course and the MIT Sports Lab, the paper argues that values like excellence, respect, and integrity are best internalised not through abstract instruction, but through practice—by embedding them in authentic, interdisciplinary learning environments. The paper highlights how rhetorical frameworks such as stasis theory and kinetic ethos help students not only analyse sports data but craft persuasive, audience-centred arguments grounded in ethical reasoning. Three scaffolded data visualisation assignments form the core of the *Writing about Sports* curriculum, culminating in predictive modelling tasks that require both technical fluency and communicative skill. These classroom practices are extended through the Sports Lab, where student research projects—such as the analysis of baseball aerodynamics and the legal classification of fantasy sports—translate analytic work into policy-relevant recommendations. The result is a model of applied Olympic education that unites theory and practice, analysis and persuasion, and prepares students to be informed, ethical actors in the world of sport and beyond.

Introduction

One of the most effective ways to cultivate Olympic values in the next generation of athletes, scholars, and citizens is by embedding those values within applied, interdisciplinary educational experiences (Binder 2012). At MIT, the pedagogical innovations in the first year subject 21W.015 Writing about Sports, offered by the programme in Writing, Rhetoric and Professional Communication (WRAP), and its alignment with the authentic experiences students have within the MIT Sports Lab offer a compelling model for how Olympic ideals—excellence, respect, and friendship—can be advanced through a combined focus on data analysis and persuasive communication. This approach not only reflects the spirit of MIT’s motto, *mens et manus* (mind and hand), but also aligns with the evolving educational priorities of the Olympic Movement in the 21st century.

Integrating Theory and Practice

MIT’s motto encapsulates the university’s commitment to integrating theoretical learning with practical application. This approach is at the heart of the rhetorical curriculum of WRAP:

- **Theory:** Students are introduced to the core principles of persuasion, rhetorical frameworks such as stasis theory, and the kinetic nature of ethos. These concepts help students analyse how arguments work, especially in complex, high-stakes environments like sports analytics or Olympic governance.
- **Practice:** Through data visualisation assignments in the first-year classroom, and capstone projects in collaboration with the MIT Sports Lab, students build persuasive visual arguments that are designed to influence real-world decisions—whether in coaching strategy, athlete performance evaluation, or sports media. These projects not only hone technical and design skills, but train students to engage stakeholders with integrity and purpose.

Rhetorical theory is not merely an academic lens but a practical, applied art—a *techne*—that equips communicators with structured strategies for persuasion, problem-solving, and audience engagement (Slater 2023). Rhetoric, according to classical definitions from Aristotle onward, is the

faculty of discerning the available means of persuasion in any given situation. Slater emphasises that rhetoric operates across all disciplines – sciences, arts, and beyond – not only as a method for organising discourse but as a vital framework for invention and critical thinking. Its tools, such as the rhetorical appeals (ethos, pathos, logos) and canons (invention, arrangement, style, memory, delivery), provide a universal architecture for communicators to adapt their arguments strategically to different audiences and contexts.

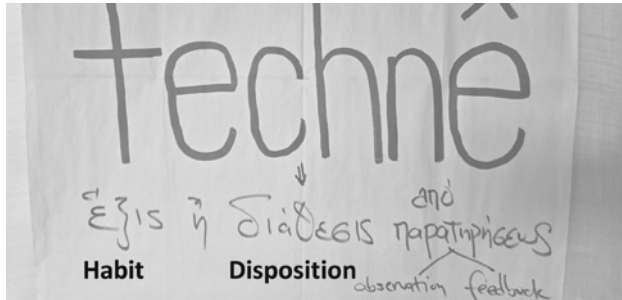


Figure 1: Ancient definition of *technē*

Rhetoric as *technē* (see Figure 1) is achieved either through habit formation (which is at the heart of all education according to Aristotle), meaning by consistent and repeated actions, or by developing a disposition “*apo paratiriseos*”, meaning that you can observe an expert in action or you can receive expert feedback which will accelerate your own learning. In essence, such an approach is aligned with our current understanding from the Learning Sciences on how mastery develops: through repeated, deliberate practice which consolidates skills and dispositions, and is accelerated through apprenticeship and feedback loops. This will become particularly relevant in our further discussion, as in interdisciplinary settings like the MIT Sports Lab or *Writing about Sports* students must move from classroom frameworks to messy, real-world problems. Mastery, then, is not about perfection, but about the development of adaptive, reliable habits grounded in both knowledge and integrated practice.

Another critical rhetorical tool, *stasis theory*, stands out as a powerful heuristic that scaffolds inquiry and argumentation. Originating in legal rhetoric, the stases provide a sequenced method for identifying and responding to the central issues in a controversy – moving from questions of fact, to definition,

to quality/value, to policy/action, and in modern applications, to legislation and decision-making. This structure does not dictate *what* to think, but rather *where* to think, opening a logical space in which ideas can be discovered, organised, and communicated effectively (Fahnestock & Secor, 1988). Stasis theory is intricately connected to *techne*: rhetoric enables skilled practice that is both artful and effective, creating the conditions for persuasive communication grounded in audience needs and situational exigencies.

Stasis theory aids in organising visual information and shaping arguments to align with audience needs and interpretive frames. By systematically addressing the stases, communicators can ensure that their visualisation representations effectively convey a targeted message. This is particularly important in data-rich contexts like sports analytics, where the goal is not only to display complex information but to translate it into actionable insights for diverse stakeholders. Incorporating stasis theory into data visualisation enhances engagement by anticipating the questions and decisions audiences must make. As Draper (2021) notes, stasis theory helps narrow and clarify research questions in STEM communication, making it an effective tool for structuring analytical narratives. Similarly, Hullman and Diakopoulos (2011) demonstrate that narrative structures in visualisations significantly influence interpretation and decision-making, thus reinforcing the idea that rhetorical framing is not optional in data communication, but essential.

In the next few sections, we intend to show how integrating stasis theory into sports data analytics projects can equip students with the tools to craft compelling data narratives that resonate with various audiences. By teaching students to consider the rhetorical aspects of data visualisation, educators can foster the development of communication strategies that effectively convey complex analyses. Our claim is that Rhetoric can become a bridge between analytic clarity and persuasive power. It opens up the possibility not just for expression, but for transformation — of beliefs, values, and actions. Finally, we'll explore how *ethos* — reconceived not as static credibility but as kinetic, evolving trust — animates the movement (*kinesis*) from insight to decision, and from data to action.

Teaching Olympic Values through the Channel of Sports Experiences

Olympic values are best internalised when they are experienced in context rather than taught in isolation. The International Olympic Committee's (IOC) Olympic Values Education Programme (OVEP) emphasises experiential learning, stating that it "uses the universality of sport in the Olympic context to support teachers and educators with the delivery of a values-based curriculum in and outside school" (OVEP 2023). In many ways, people become the values not by studying them but by learning them – through participation, iteration, and reflection. In other words, values are not absorbed through formal instruction alone, but through what education scholars call the "hidden curriculum": the subtle, often unspoken ways in which behaviours, habits, and ethics are modelled and acquired. In sport, this hidden curriculum is especially powerful. Players learn teamwork, fairness, resilience, and responsibility through the lived experience of competition and cooperation.

Writing about Sports channels this principle by meeting students where they're at, both through their deep personal engagement in athletics or interest in sports culture, and through their level of communication skills, and introducing them to analytic and rhetorical tools that help make sense of those experiences. Students are invited to examine their own roles within sports as full, peripheral, or even outside participants in larger discourse communities. Importantly, the course design acknowledges that meaning-making in sport is not confined to elite performance or top-tier analytics. Instead, the learning environment aims to connect with all students, regardless of their prior expertise, and values the contribution of personal insight, emotional intelligence, and communicative empathy alongside data fluency.

This inclusive, values-forward approach mirrors the goals of the Olympic Values Education Programme (OVEP), which promotes learning that combines physical activity with cultural and intellectual development. As Theodorakis, Georgiadis, and Hassandra (2024) argue, Olympic education must respond to contemporary global challenges by fostering holistic development across domains of knowledge, behaviour, and ethics. This instance of the first-year MIT curriculum does precisely this by embedding ethical and rhetorical reasoning into sport-centred, data-rich learning environments.

We can think of the marathon analogy to further emphasise this inclusive,

humanistic ethos: Olympic education, like a marathon, should not only celebrate those out in front but must also be structured to bring along the ones who are struggling. In the MIT classroom, that means building scaffolds for students at all levels, valuing diverse entry points into discourse, and fostering a community that learns collaboratively rather than competitively.

A powerful illustration of this approach can be drawn from football history: Johan Cruyff and the development of Total Football. Cruyff revolutionised not only the tactics of the game but also the pedagogy of sport by teaching players *how to think*, not just what to do (Wilson 1998). His method blended technical drills with a worldview grounded in ethics and aesthetics. Students of Cruyff's philosophy, including Pep Guardiola, learned to recognise space and flow, to value intelligence and teamwork as pathways to beauty on the field. Total Football is a living metaphor for Olympic pedagogy: it teaches a relationship with sport that is contextual, ethical, and thoughtful. It shows that athletic training can be an education in reasoning, in looking, and in framing: in other words, in learning how to think.

Creating the Conditions for a Well-Rounded Educational Experience

One of the notable examples of MIT's integrated approach to teaching values through rhetorical and technical skill-building is the *Writing about Sports* course. As a Communication Intensive subject in the humanities (CI-HW), this course introduces first-year students to rhetorical frameworks, genre analysis, visual reasoning, and argument construction through the lens of sports media and analytics. It provides students with opportunities to both critique and create data-driven communication with real-world stakes, blending the ethical dimensions of persuasion with the technical elements of data interpretation.

A central feature of the course is a sequence of three scaffolded assignments focused on data visualisation and argumentation:

- 1. Rhetorical Analysis of a Visual:** Students begin by selecting an existing data visualisation and conducting a rhetorical analysis. They deliver a 7–10-minute teaching presentation in which they unpack the visual design, audience, context, and persuasive strategy. The goal is to help peers better understand how data-based visuals communicate and persuade.
- 2. Descriptive Visualisation of Data:** In the second assignment, students

create an original data visualisation using historical data. Here, the emphasis shifts from analysis to argument. Students are asked in their presentations and visualisations to answer questions related to causation or quality (e.g., why a team performed well, or whether a referee system was fair) and to craft a visual story that supports a specific claim through careful design and interpretation.

- 3. Predictive Visualisation of Data:** In the final assignment in this sequence, students build predictive arguments for a competition that is taking place at that time (e.g. the 2022 World Cup or the 2023 NBA playoffs). They must answer questions such as which teams will advance, what the match outcomes will be, and who will score most or concede least. Points are awarded not only for accuracy but for persuasiveness: students must convince their peers to adopt their predictions when filling out tournament brackets. This assignment demands the highest integration of rhetorical skill, data literacy, and targeted persuasion.

Through this sequence, students progressively develop their ability to construct visual arguments grounded in data, situated within a rhetorical situation, and oriented toward specific decisions or actions. Each assignment moves them further along the continuum from observation to invention, from critique to practice.

Central to the course is a lecture on data visualisation, where students are taught to merge analytical thinking with communicative clarity. Drawing from visual design theory and rhetorical practice, students engage with questions such as: What stories does the data tell? Who is the audience for this data? What action should the data provoke? These questions reflect the stasis-based scaffolding of the curriculum, in which arguments about fact, definition, quality, and policy are visually explored and strategically arranged. Class lectures and activities provide theoretical grounding and practical tools for students to analyse, design, and deliver persuasive visual arguments.

Students are also introduced to a wide range of rhetorical decisions embedded in visualisation, including how data is selected, filtered, represented, and framed. Concepts such as visual metaphor, contrast, classification, and mapping from data to design are covered in detail, showing students how every visualisation inherently makes an argument. Hullman and Diakopoulos's concept of the "rhetorical nature of visualisation design" is highlighted to underscore that even the most data-driven visual must engage

in simplification and narrative abstraction, and therefore inevitably enters the domain of persuasion.

In classroom hands-on workshops, students storyboard their presentations, aligning visual decisions with rhetorical goals. Each visual is treated as an argumentative unit, shaped by genre conventions and audience expectations. In this way, the course embodies rhetorical *praxis*: using rhetorical theory to equip students with the skills to analyse data and communicate it in forms that move audiences toward informed understanding and action.

In the Fall 2022 version of the course, students were tasked with analysing two assigned qualifying groups from the 2022 FIFA World Cup and answering specific, granular questions: Which teams will qualify? What will be the order of group finish? What are the predicted outcomes of each match? Who will score the most and concede the least? To respond, students had to construct visualisations, and then deliver live presentations, that combined historical performance data, player statistics, and team metrics into a coherent, forward-looking argument. One of the rhetorical concepts they were introduced to was *invented ethos*, where they learned how to establish credibility through good will towards the audience (*eunoia*), practical wisdom (*phronesis*) and overall excellence of approach and reasoning (*arete*). Their visualisations had to be designed to carry the persuasive force of a recommendation: not just *what is likely*, but *what you should believe and act on*. When listening to their classmates present, students navigated tensions between their own preconceived ideas and new points shared by the presenter. Instructors explicitly tie assessment to rhetorical impact by measuring how many classmates align their own “predictive” bracket decisions with the presenter’s predictions (see Figure 2). Here, persuasion is just as important as correctness, mirroring many real-world settings that value communication over expertise.

			Foppers		Fishermen		The Dawgs	
			Group A	Group B	Group A	Group C	Group B	Group D
Correct team progression outcome	8 points per correct team (32)	32	8 ▾	▾	16 ▾	▾		0 ▾
Correct team position	3 points per correct team (24)	24	3 ▾	▾	12 ▾	▾	▾	▾
Correct match result	2 points per correct prediction (24)	24	6 ▾	2 ▾	8 ▾	2 ▾	4 ▾	6 ▾
Correct most GF	3 points per prediction (6)	6	3 ▾	▾	3 ▾	▾	▾	▾
Correct least GA	3 points per prediction (6)	6	0 ▾	▾	0 ▾	▾	▾	▾
Correct best GD	3 points per prediction (6)	6	3 ▾	▾	3 ▾	▾	▾	▾
Prediction total for each group	Maximum of 49 points		23	2	42	2	4	6
Bonus for total head to head win	15 for each win	30	0 ▾	▾	15 ▾	▾	▾	▾
People following R16 prediction	2 points per person/team (24*24)	48	12 ▾	22 ▾	20 ▾	22 ▾	22 ▾	24 ▾
	1 point per person/team for order (12*12)	24	2 ▾	0 ▾	10 ▾	11 ▾	10 ▾	10 ▾
	Total group points		37	24	87	35	36	40
TOTAL	Total team points	200	61		122		76	

Figure 2: Scores spreadsheet for predictive visualisations of 2022 World Cup assignment

This assignment encapsulates the shift from rhetorical analysis to rhetorical praxis, reinforcing the idea that data is a persuasive medium. It also showcases the kinetic nature of ethos, as students must build and perform their authority dynamically, responding to audience questions and adjusting based on perceived credibility and presentation style. The strategic choices—what data to include, how to visualise trends, which claims to emphasise—all reflect the application of rhetorical theory (particularly stasis and ethos) in the service of real-time audience persuasion and immediate action. This requires all the skills developed in this pipeline of assignments: description, prediction, and persuasion. As a capstone, it elegantly synthesises the course’s dual focus on data literacy and communicative power.

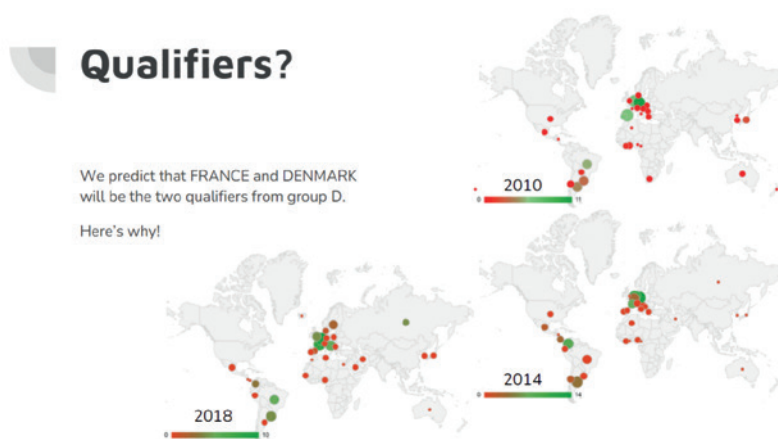


Figure 3: Example of analysis for 2022 World Cup assignment

The pedagogy here treats values not as supplementary or ornamental, but as central to functional expertise. Rhetorical-based communication, just like statistical reasoning or visual design, requires an understanding of systems: how data flows, how persuasion works, how decisions are made, and how audiences respond (extending the work of Senge 2006). In this way, the pedagogy of values becomes both an art and a science, woven into the very fabric of each learning task.

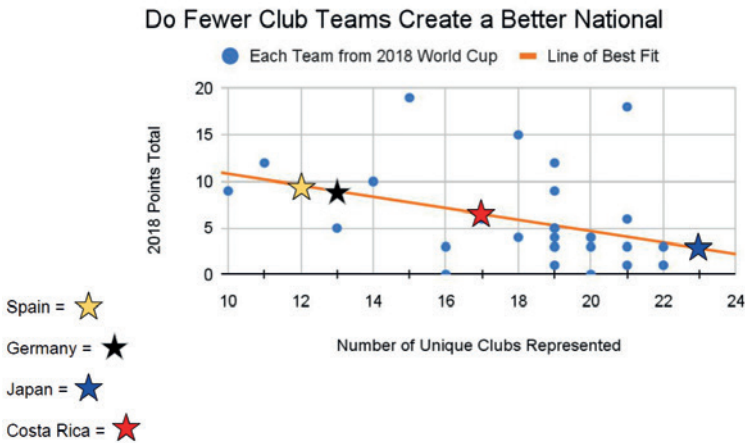


Figure 4: Example of analysis for 2022 World Cup assignment

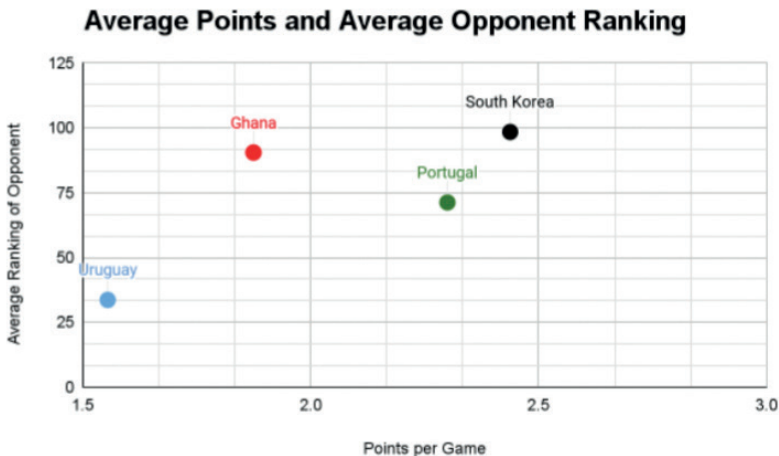


Figure 5: Example of analysis for 2022 World Cup assignment

This emphasis on communication as a persuasive and social act speaks directly to John Milton-Smith's (2002) observation that the Olympics are uniquely positioned to foster a global conversation about shared values. By engaging with both rhetorical concepts and statistical reasoning, students are trained to move beyond abstract ideals and into the realm of practical, persuasive civic engagement. They are, in essence, learning to be communicators of global values through the specific and relatable medium of sport.

This philosophy is carried forward in the capstone experience of many students through their participation in the MIT Sports Lab (<https://sportslab.mit.edu/>). The Sports Lab serves as a research and innovation hub where upper-level undergraduates and graduate students work with external partners—such as professional leagues, federations, and performance organisations—on real-world projects. These experiences allow students to engage with complex, often ambiguous challenges that require both technical problem-solving and rhetorical savvy. Only founded in the last decade, the Sports Lab connects the MIT research community with partners spanning various sports and nations, such as FIFA in Switzerland, the NBA in the United States, and the Australian Cycling Federation. The Sports Lab spans a plethora of academic disciplines, such as data analytics, mechanical engineering, computer vision, and materials science. This allows students on campus to combine their love for sports with their academic passions in project-based settings. Deliverables frequently culminate in policy recommendations, tools, or interventions that are designed for implementation beyond the classroom.

One notable example is the study conducted on Major League baseballs, addressing the so-called "juiced ball" controversy. Prompted by a sharp rise in home runs after 2015, MIT students collaborated with physicists and engineers to analyse the aerodynamic properties of baseballs using experimental methods and StatCast data. They found measurable differences in the drag coefficient due to seemingly minor variations in seam height and lace thickness. These small physical changes were shown to have amplified effects on ball flight—adding up to a 25% increase in home run rates (Albert, Hosoi, Nathan, & Smith, 2019). The findings were presented to Major League Baseball and contributed to broader conversations about transparency and equipment regulation in the sport.

This project exemplifies the integration of technical expertise and communicative clarity. It shows how MIT students, supported by a values-driven pedagogical model, are empowered to influence professional practice through rigorous, persuasive, and actionable work.

Why did the drag coefficient change?

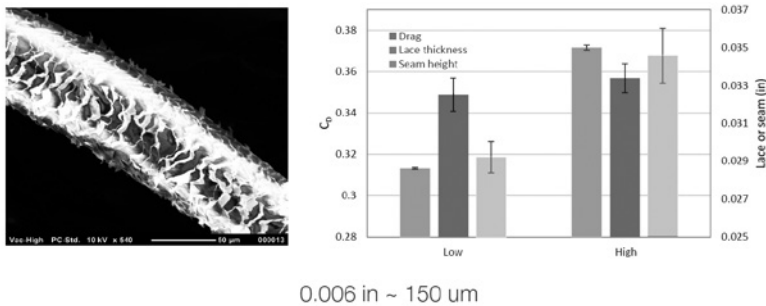


Figure 6: Analysis of the drag coefficient (Sports Lab project)

A second example from the MIT Sports Lab that illustrates the integration of technical analysis with persuasive, real-world application is the “Luck and the Law” project, which addressed the legal classification of fantasy sports as either games of chance or skill. Motivated by growing regulatory scrutiny, this student-led project—conducted in partnership with FanDuel—developed a novel, quantitative metric to distinguish between outcomes primarily driven by chance versus those driven by skill. The team applied statistical and Monte Carlo methods to extensive datasets from daily fantasy sports competitions across multiple leagues, producing robust evidence that player performance consistently deviated from random expectation and exhibited persistent skill-based outcomes. Beyond the technical rigour, the persuasive force of the study lay in its clarity and policy relevance: by demonstrating that the majority of top-performing players outperformed simulated chance-based rosters, and by offering a skill-to-luck continuum with precise positioning of fantasy sports among other activities (e.g., poker, mutual funds, professional leagues), the project offered actionable recommendations for stakeholders in both the legal and commercial domains. This work exemplifies the MIT Sports Lab’s pedagogical mission—preparing students to navigate ambiguity,

communicate complexity, and influence real-world decisions through a rigorous integration of analysis and ethical reasoning.

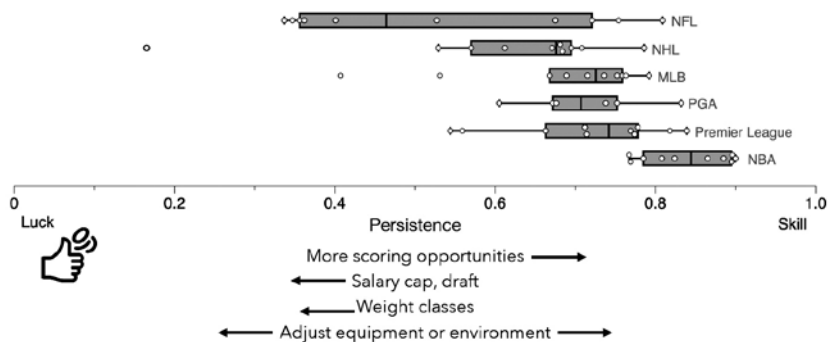


Figure 7: Analysis of luck vs skill in different sports (Sports Lab project)

Through their work in the classroom and in collaboration with the MIT Sports Lab, students not only interpret and produce sophisticated data analyses, but also learn how to communicate those analyses to stakeholders. Students experience the intricacies of a real-world team environment, working with fellow students, faculty, and industry partners at all levels. Students are being prepared not simply as data scientists or writers, but as ethical persuaders who can move audiences toward action—an educational goal that lies at the very heart of the Olympic mission.

Conclusions

The integration of rhetorical theory with data visualisation and technical analysis, as demonstrated in MIT's *Writing about Sports* course and the MIT Sports Lab, offers a powerful framework for cultivating Olympic values in an applied educational setting. Rather than teaching ethics, sportsmanship, and excellence in abstraction, this model embeds them directly into the learning experience—through projects that require students to think critically, communicate persuasively, and engage authentically with real-world problems. Concepts such as *techné*, stasis theory, and kinetic ethos are not just intellectual tools; they become habits

of mind and practice that shape how students analyse data, construct arguments, and respond to the needs of diverse audiences. Just as Johan Cruyff's famous Total Football teams learned how to reason on the pitch, these rhetorical concepts empower students to learn reasoning skills in and beyond the classroom. In this way, students are not simply learning about values—they are enacting them.

This model of education, grounded in the Olympic spirit, prepares students not only to be better analysts or communicators, but to be ethical and impactful participants in society. As the MIT Sports Lab projects illustrate, the transition from classroom to real-world implementation demands not only technical precision, but rhetorical clarity, ethical awareness, and audience sensitivity. Whether they are evaluating fairness in World Cup officiating, or contributing to Major League Baseball policy decisions, students at MIT are being trained to bridge the gap between data and action, between insight and impact, all with the attitude of mind and hand.

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AI AND EDUCATION: A NEW PEDAGOGICAL FRONTIER IN OLYMPIC CULTURE

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Abstract

This paper explores the transformative role of artificial intelligence (AI) in contemporary education, particularly within the evolving context of Olympic culture. Emphasising the synergy between human and artificial intelligence, it examines AI's potential to redefine pedagogical paradigms, empower learners, and foster ethically resilient educators. The analysis extends to the application of AI in sport education and esports, where Olympic values such as Excellence, Respect, and Fair Play encounter digital disruption. The study proposes a framework for ethically grounded, inclusive, and experiential learning that aligns with the Olympic spirit in the digital age.

1. Introduction: A New Epistemological Convergence

In every era, education has served as a mirror of civilization's prevailing values, methods, and aspirations. It is not merely a mechanism for knowledge transfer, but a dynamic process of intellectual awakening, ethical formation, and civic preparation. At its most profound, education shapes the human condition – inviting learners not only to understand the world but to reimagine and transform it.

In parallel, AI has emerged not simply as a technological innovation, but

as a paradigmatic shift in how intelligence itself is understood, operationalised, and extended. The ability of machines to simulate human reasoning, interpret language, identify patterns, and make decisions represents a profound transformation — one that redefines our relationship with knowledge, agency, and even creativity.

The convergence of these two domains — human intelligence and artificial intelligence — demands a re-examination of our educational philosophy. This is not a superficial intersection of tools and pedagogy, but a deep epistemological inflection point. It challenges us to ask: *What does it mean to learn in an age where machines can "know"? What becomes of teaching when algorithms can adaptively instruct? What new literacies, ethics, and forms of consciousness must we cultivate to remain not merely relevant, but deeply human?*

In this light, AI should not be understood as a threat to educational values, but as a catalyst for their reinvigoration. It provides the impetus to reimagine the learner as an active constructor of meaning in a hybrid cognitive environment, and the educator as a designer of transformative experiences that transcend temporal and spatial limitations.

Much like sport — which unites body, mind, and moral discipline — education augmented by AI must aim for holistic development. AI, when guided by ethical intent and pedagogical wisdom, can act as a *cognitive exoskeleton*, extending the reach of the mind, scaffolding the learning journey, and democratising access to high-quality instruction. In this synthesis, technology does not displace the educator's role — it demands its evolution.

We are thus entering a new epistemological era: one in which intelligence is not confined to biological substrates, but shared across human and artificial agents. This convergence calls for a renewed educational purpose — not simply to compete with machines, but to cultivate what machines cannot: empathy, judgment, curiosity, and ethical imagination. These are the attributes that define both the spirit of Olympism and the promise of humanistic education in the digital age.

In short, this paper proposes that AI, far from replacing the human educator, serves as a medium through which education can be more inclusive, personalised, and ethically grounded. To embrace this convergence is not to surrender to automation, but to seize the opportunity to elevate the mission of education to its highest form: the shaping of augmented, autonomous, and morally aware human beings.

2. Transforming Pedagogy: The Current Landscape of AI in Education

As the digital revolution matures into the era of intelligent systems, the educational landscape finds itself undergoing a radical metamorphosis. No longer confined to supporting administrative efficiency or content delivery, artificial intelligence (AI) has emerged as a powerful pedagogical agent—capable of reconfiguring how knowledge is accessed, how learners engage, and how educators design meaningful learning experiences.

This transformation is not merely technological—it is philosophical. It reflects a shift from linear, uniform models of instruction toward dynamic, personalised, and data-informed pedagogies. AI technologies are not simply "tools" to be used—they are co-constructors of learning environments, bearing epistemological implications about what counts as knowledge, how it is validated, and by whom it is interpreted.

We now inhabit a reality in which AI algorithms can analyse learning behaviours, adaptively modify instructional content in real time, and even provide nuanced feedback on learners' emotional and cognitive states. These affordances challenge the traditional architecture of education, moving us away from one-size-fits-all models toward ecosystems of responsive, inclusive, and equitable learning.

Three key domains exemplify this paradigm shift:

2.1 Adaptive Learning Systems: Toward Individualised Intellectual Journeys

Imagine a learning system where the curriculum is not pre-set but co-evolves with the learner—where educational trajectories are tailored in real-time to meet the unique profile of each student. This is the promise of adaptive learning, made possible through sophisticated AI algorithms that detect patterns in learner performance, engagement, and behaviour.

Platforms such as Squirrel AI, Knewton, and Century Tech exemplify this new era of personalisation. These systems deconstruct the myth of the "average learner", offering differentiated scaffolding for those who struggle, while accelerating opportunities for enrichment among advanced students. In doing so, adaptive learning does not merely promote efficiency—it reclaims the ethical imperative of equity. Every learner deserves a curriculum that acknowledges their pace, context, and potential.

Furthermore, adaptive learning reframes assessment itself. No longer a discrete, summative act, evaluation becomes an ongoing dialogue between the system and the learner – a formative, data-rich process that supports reflection, resilience, and self-directed growth.

2.2 Virtual Tutors and Conversational Agents: Reimagining Dialogue at Scale

At the heart of effective pedagogy lies the capacity for meaningful dialogue – the exchange of questions, ideas, and feedback in the co-construction of knowledge. In contexts marked by overcrowded classrooms or limited educator availability, AI-powered conversational agents are reimagining how such dialogue is initiated and sustained.

Virtual tutors such as ChatGPT, Google Gemini, and domain-specific educational bots are now capable of responding to learners' inquiries, providing just-in-time explanations, and prompting metacognitive reflection. Crucially, these agents are not bound by human limitations – they are infinitely patient, non-judgmental, and available around the clock.

In this light, AI does not replace human mentorship; it extends it. It ensures that learners, regardless of background or geography, can access cognitive companionship – engaging in dialogic learning even in the absence of a human interlocutor. This is particularly vital in underserved communities, where AI may serve as a pedagogical equaliser.

2.3 AI-Powered Assessment and Feedback: From Performance to Potential

Traditional assessment systems have long been critiqued for their reductive focus on outcomes over process, on answers rather than understanding. AI enables a departure from this paradigm by offering multi-dimensional insights into how learners think, feel, and progress.

Through natural language processing, sentiment analysis, and biometric data (such as eye movement or response latency), AI systems can construct sophisticated learner profiles that capture cognitive effort, emotional engagement, and behavioural patterns. These insights can inform educators in real time, allowing for immediate interventions, personalised guidance, and enhanced learner self-awareness.

In essence, AI transforms assessment from a judgmental snapshot to a developmental mirror. It encourages students to monitor their learning strategies,

regulate their emotional states, and develop a meta-awareness of their cognitive processes. This is not assessment *of* learning, but *for* learning—and ultimately, as learning.

In sum, AI is not simply enhancing pedagogical tools—it is redefining pedagogy itself. It enables a shift from didactic instruction to personalised inquiry, from passive reception to active construction, and from standardisation to inclusivity. The educator's role, in turn, becomes more strategic, ethical, and human: to orchestrate experiences that cultivate not just knowledge, but wisdom, empathy, and critical consciousness in an age of algorithmic mediation.

3. Redefining the Role of the Educator

The advent of artificial intelligence in education has reignited a profound and perennial question: *What is the role of the educator in a world where information is abundant, answers are automated, and instructional support is algorithmically rendered?* For many, the rise of AI triggers fears of professional obsolescence and pedagogical displacement. Such concerns are not unfounded—but they are ultimately misplaced.

Rather than heralding the end of the educator, AI compels a redefinition of their mission—urging a transition from the industrial-era logic of standardisation to a post-digital paradigm centred on personalisation, criticality, and empowerment. Educators are not being replaced by AI; they are being called to ascend to higher-order roles that no machine can emulate: those of mentor, ethicist, coach, and architect of transformative learning experiences.

In this new pedagogical frontier, the educator emerges not as a transmitter of fixed knowledge but as a cultivator of *epistemic agency*—the learner's capacity to ask questions, evaluate evidence, and construct meaning autonomously and ethically. To fulfil this reimagined role, educators must embrace and develop a multifaceted professional identity:

3.1 The Educator as Curator of Authentic Learning

In an age of infinite content, the value of the educator lies not in mere dissemination, but in *curation*. The educator must now serve as an intentional designer of learning environments—selecting, sequencing, and contextualising

both digital and embodied resources to create experiences that are coherent, meaningful, and intellectually rigorous.

This involves integrating AI-powered systems in ways that amplify human understanding without reducing it to efficiency metrics. It means blending technology with narrative, dialogue, and affective engagement to foster deeper cognitive and emotional connections with knowledge. The educator, in this sense, becomes a mediator between information and wisdom.

3.2 The Educator as Cognitive Coach

As AI assumes routine instructional functions—such as grading, tutoring, or content adaptation—the educator’s role expands into *cognitive coaching*: helping learners build the dispositions and strategies necessary for self-regulation, metacognition, and lifelong learning.

This requires guiding students in developing critical literacies: not only digital and media literacy, but also *algorithmic literacy*—the capacity to understand, interrogate, and navigate AI systems. The educator must equip learners to ask not only *how* AI works, but *why*, *for whom*, and *with what consequences*.

By fostering habits of reflection, discernment, and ethical inquiry, educators can empower students not just to *use* technology—but to understand its limitations, critique its biases, and imagine its alternatives.

3.3 The Educator as Orchestrator of Inquiry

Inquiry is the cornerstone of deep learning. In a world saturated with answers, the educator must revive the primacy of questions. AI may be able to generate information, but it cannot substitute for the *why* of learning—the inner motivation that drives discovery, creativity, and ethical action.

Thus, educators must become *orchestrators of inquiry-based pedagogy*: creating conditions for collaborative exploration, hypothesis testing, and real-world problem solving. This means designing learning experiences that are open-ended, interdisciplinary, and reflective of complex global challenges—from climate change to digital ethics.

In this role, the educator becomes a choreographer of curiosity, cultivating environments where learners are encouraged to take intellectual risks, embrace uncertainty, and generate novel insights. The classroom transforms from a site of transmission into a laboratory of critical thought and civic imagination.

This redefinition also carries with it a moral imperative: to prepare learners not only to *coexist* with intelligent systems, but to *lead* in shaping the values, purposes, and policies that govern them. As such, the role of the educator becomes deeply political and ethical—charged with the task of forming citizens who are not merely consumers of technology, but agents of democratic transformation.

In summary, the educator of the AI era is not an endangered species. Rather, they are a *re-evolved professional*—uniquely positioned to amplify human potential in partnership with intelligent technologies. This is not a diminution of the educator’s role—it is its elevation.

By embracing this shift, we affirm that while machines may replicate intelligence, only educators can nurture wisdom, conscience, and the ethical courage required to navigate an uncertain future. In this lies the enduring—and indeed expanding—relevance of the human educator.

4. Olympism and AI: Ethical Synergies

As artificial intelligence increasingly permeates the educational landscape, it becomes imperative not only to examine its capabilities but also to interrogate its values. Technology is never neutral; it reflects the intentions, biases, and assumptions of its creators and implementers. Thus, the integration of AI into education demands an explicit ethical compass—one that aligns with a broader humanistic vision of learning, development, and global citizenship.

In this regard, the philosophy of Olympism—rooted in the principles of *Excellence*, *Respect*, and *Fair Play*—offers a powerful normative framework through which the use of AI in education can be reimagined and guided. These Olympic values are not merely sportsmanship ideals; they represent a pedagogical ethos that speaks directly to the kind of character, community, and culture we seek to foster in the digital age.

By engaging with AI through the lens of Olympism, we are invited to view technology not as an isolated system of logic, but as a human-centred ecosystem—one whose design, deployment, and governance must uphold the dignity of the learner and the sanctity of the educational process.

4.1 Excellence: From Technical Optimisation to Human Flourishing

Olympic excellence transcends winning—it embodies the pursuit of one’s best

self, the striving for continual improvement, and the courage to act with integrity even under pressure. Transposed into the educational use of AI, *excellence* must not be reduced to metrics of performance optimisation or algorithmic efficiency. Rather, it must emphasise *wisdom over automation, judgment over acceleration, and purpose over productivity*.

An ethical application of AI in education should therefore foster intellectual rigour, emotional intelligence, and moral development – not just cognitive gains or test scores. This means designing AI systems that encourage reflection, cultivate curiosity, and support learners in setting meaningful goals aligned with personal and societal values. AI must enhance – not eclipse – the human capacity for growth, responsibility, and transcendence.

4.2 Respect: Designing for Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

The Olympic principle of respect encompasses reverence for the rules, for one's opponents, and for the diversity of all people. In the context of AI, respect demands a commitment to building systems that are *inclusive by design* – attuned to linguistic, cultural, cognitive, and socio-economic diversity.

Too often, AI systems in education are trained on datasets that encode dominant cultural norms while marginalising alternative perspectives. This can lead to homogenised learning experiences and the inadvertent reproduction of structural inequalities. By contrast, a pedagogy of respect insists that AI systems recognise, affirm, and celebrate the multiplicity of learners' identities, backgrounds, and learning styles.

Furthermore, respect entails safeguarding the *privacy, agency, and consent* of all learners. As data collection becomes more ubiquitous, ethical AI must ensure transparency, explainability, and user control – so that learners are never objectified as data points but honoured as persons with voice and autonomy.

4.3 Fair Play: Ensuring Justice in Algorithmic Systems

Fair play lies at the heart of both Olympic competition and democratic education. It denotes a commitment to transparency, impartiality, and ethical accountability. In the age of AI, *fair play* requires vigilant attention to the risks of algorithmic bias, opaque decision-making, and unequal access to technological resources.

Educators and technologists alike must therefore advocate for *algorithmic justice*: AI systems that are auditable, open-source, and designed with

interdisciplinary oversight. This includes implementing safeguards against discrimination, establishing clear protocols for data governance, and promoting AI literacy among all stakeholders – especially those from historically underrepresented communities.

Moreover, fairness in AI must extend beyond technical parameters to the broader sociopolitical structures in which these systems operate. It demands systemic equity – ensuring that all learners, regardless of geographic or economic context, can benefit from high-quality, ethically developed educational AI.

In uniting the timeless ethical spirit of Olympism with the emergent power of AI, we can forge a vision of education that is both technologically advanced and morally grounded. This is not a matter of idealism but of strategic necessity. Without ethical anchoring, AI risks becoming a force of exclusion, surveillance, and commodification. With Olympism as its compass, however, AI can be harnessed as a vehicle for equity, character development, and global solidarity.

Thus, the challenge before us is clear: to ensure that AI in education does not merely reflect the world as it is, but helps shape the world as it ought to be. It is through this ethical synergy – between digital innovation and Olympic humanism – that we can construct a pedagogical future worthy of both our technological potential and our shared humanity.

5. AI and Sport Education: Embodying Olympic Pedagogy

Sport has long served as a pedagogical arena where physical discipline intersects with moral development. In the Olympic tradition, athletic practice is not merely a test of strength or skill, but a profound expression of human values – excellence, respect, perseverance, solidarity, and fair competition. The field of sport education, therefore, holds a unique place in the broader educational ecosystem: it cultivates not only bodies, but also characters; not only abilities, but also ideals.

In the digital age, this pedagogical mission is being transformed through the intelligent integration of artificial intelligence. AI in sport education is not limited to performance analytics or technological augmentation – it has the potential to become a powerful vehicle for *embodied ethics*, enabling learners to experience, reflect on, and internalise Olympic values in immersive and authentic ways.

When thoughtfully designed and ethically deployed, AI can animate Olympic pedagogy in three interconnected dimensions: enhancing performance through

personalised feedback, enriching learning through immersive simulation, and cultivating values through experiential dilemmas.

5.1 Precision and Personalisation: AI-Enhanced Athletic Development

In elite and amateur sport alike, AI-driven systems are revolutionising training by offering granular insights into biomechanics, physiology, and performance trends. Machine learning algorithms analyse movement patterns, detect asymmetries, and predict injury risks – allowing for individualised training plans that optimise performance while minimising harm.

In educational contexts, such technologies serve a dual purpose. First, they allow learners to understand the *science* of sport through real-time feedback and data visualisation – fostering data literacy, critical interpretation, and applied learning. Second, they embody the Olympic ideal of *excellence* by supporting each learner's journey toward their personal best.

This personalisation does not merely concern athletic metrics; it reflects a deeper commitment to equity. By adapting coaching methods to diverse bodies, abilities, and learning styles, AI supports inclusive physical education where all students – regardless of background or aptitude – can grow, thrive, and experience the joy of mastery.

5.2 Immersive Learning and Simulation: Bringing Ethical Complexity to Life

One of the most exciting frontiers of AI in sport education lies in the creation of immersive, interactive environments where learners can engage in complex decision-making scenarios. Through AI-powered simulations and virtual reality experiences, students can now navigate dilemmas that mirror real-world challenges in the sporting world.

Imagine a scenario in which a learner assumes the role of a young athlete pressured to use performance-enhancing substances. Or a digital simulation where one must manage a multicultural team facing discrimination, conflict, or exclusion. These platforms – powered by AI narrative engines and adaptive branching – provide emotionally rich, contextually grounded spaces where students can wrestle with moral ambiguity and practice ethical judgment.

Such experiences embody Olympic pedagogy not through rote memorisation of values, but through *lived moral engagement*. Learners come to understand that respect, integrity, and solidarity are not abstract ideals, but active choices

made under conditions of pressure and uncertainty. AI, in this context, becomes a catalyst for character education – helping learners cultivate ethical reflexes in tandem with cognitive and physical development.

5.3 Esport and Digital Athleticism: A New Arena for Olympic Education

The inclusion of esport within Olympic discourse signals a paradigm shift in how we define sport and competition. While digital games may lack the physicality of traditional athletics, they nonetheless involve teamwork, strategic thinking, resilience, and ethical tension – attributes central to Olympic education.

AI is already deeply embedded in esport ecosystems: as opponents, coaches, match analysers, and training companions. These intelligent agents can dynamically adjust difficulty, analyse gameplay behaviour, and offer tailored feedback to foster player growth. But beyond skill acquisition, AI in esport can also serve as a *moral provocateur* – presenting players with scenarios that test sportsmanship, inclusion, and respect.

Educators have an opportunity to reframe esport not as escapist entertainment, but as a *learning platform* where Olympic values can be explored and embodied. With carefully constructed AI systems, learners can experience the tension between winning and fairness, collaboration and competition, or strategy and empathy. In this way, the digital arena becomes a legitimate space for ethical and pedagogical development.

Ultimately, AI in sport education must be more than a tool for efficiency or novelty. It must be a *conduit for human formation*, guided by the same ideals that animate the Olympic spirit. Through intelligent augmentation, educators can design experiences where learners not only improve their physical abilities, but also refine their ethical awareness, emotional intelligence, and intercultural competence.

By aligning AI innovation with Olympic pedagogy, we do not abandon tradition – we extend it. We reaffirm that the purpose of sport is not only to win, but to become – stronger, wiser, more just. And through this lens, sport education becomes a transformative arena where AI and humanity run not in opposition, but stride for stride, toward a shared horizon of dignity, excellence, and peace.

6. Challenges and Future Research Directions

As artificial intelligence continues to expand its influence across the educational landscape, it presents a dual reality: on one hand, a generative force capable of democratising knowledge, enhancing personalisation, and enabling inclusive innovation; on the other, a disruptive power that can deepen inequities, entrench biases, and erode fundamental ethical norms if left unexamined.

The task before educators, researchers, and policymakers is not simply to adopt AI—but to *interrogate, shape, and humanise it*. This requires a research agenda that is both critical and creative—rooted in ethical foresight, cross-disciplinary collaboration, and a deep commitment to justice. In short, it requires a spirit of *Olympic inquiry*: courageous, principled, and globally engaged.

6.1 Epistemological Questions: Who Defines Knowledge in AI-Supported Learning?

One of the most urgent challenges lies in interrogating the epistemologies embedded in AI systems. Most AI-powered educational platforms are trained on data drawn from dominant linguistic, cultural, and epistemic contexts. This raises fundamental questions:

- Whose knowledge is represented, and whose is excluded?
- What assumptions underlie the design of these systems?
- To what extent does AI risk reproducing educational colonialism by privileging certain norms of learning, reasoning, or communication?

Future research must critically examine the cultural foundations of AI-driven content and develop inclusive models that integrate diverse ways of knowing, teaching, and learning. This includes Indigenous pedagogies, experiential methods, and context-sensitive frameworks that reflect the heterogeneity of learners worldwide.

6.2 Algorithmic Bias, Transparency, and Accountability

Despite the veneer of objectivity, AI systems are susceptible to replicating and even amplifying social biases. When used in high-stakes educational decisions—such as admissions, assessment, or behavioural monitoring—such biases can have serious consequences, particularly for marginalised communities.

Research must thus explore robust frameworks for *algorithmic transparency, fairness, and explainability*. This includes:

- Developing methods for auditing AI models used in educational settings
- Engaging students and educators in participatory design processes
- Establishing clear ethical standards and regulatory mechanisms that protect learner rights, agency, and privacy

The principle of *fair play*—so central to Olympic ethics—must become a foundational criterion for AI deployment in education. AI should not be permitted to render invisible the mechanisms of exclusion; rather, it must be designed to expose and correct them.

6.3 Socioeconomic and Infrastructural Gaps

Access to AI-enhanced education remains uneven across regions, institutions, and social strata. In many contexts, the digital divide continues to limit the potential of even the most promising technologies. This inequity is compounded when AI systems are expensive, proprietary, or dependent on high-end infrastructure.

Thus, future research must focus on *open-source, low-cost, and locally adaptable AI solutions*, especially for use in resource-constrained environments. It must also address questions such as:

- How can AI be designed to operate effectively in low-bandwidth or offline settings?
- What training and capacity-building are needed for educators to use AI meaningfully?
- How can partnerships between academia, civil society, and the private sector foster equitable AI ecosystems?

These questions are not merely technical—they are political and ethical. A truly Olympic vision of AI in education must ensure that no learner is left behind in the digital age.

6.4 Ethical-by-Design and Human-Centred AI Development

The future of AI in education must move beyond reactive ethics toward *proactive ethical design*. This means embedding human values, democratic principles, and pedagogical goals at every stage of the development lifecycle.

Future research should prioritise:

- *Human-centred design methodologies* that reflect learners' aspirations and educators' realities
- *Interdisciplinary collaboration* among technologists, ethicists, psychologists, and educators
- *Ethical frameworks* grounded in human rights, global citizenship, and sustainability

In particular, Olympic pedagogy can contribute a unique lens — emphasising the formative role of education in character building, peace-making, and intercultural dialogue. AI systems must not merely reflect user behaviour; they should inspire ethical growth and civic responsibility.

In conclusion, the challenges of AI in education are not obstacles to be feared — they are opportunities to be *courageously embraced*. They invite a new generation of researchers and practitioners to step forward with the intellectual rigour and moral clarity worthy of the Olympic legacy.

Let us approach the future of AI and education not as passive recipients of technological inevitability, but as active co-creators of an educational vision grounded in equity, excellence, and ethical resolve. Let us formulate research agendas that transcend disciplinary silos, prioritise human dignity, and embody the very spirit of Olympism: striving not only for what is possible, but for what is just.

7. Conclusion: Toward a New Olympic Pedagogy

As we stand at the confluence of technological innovation and educational transformation, we are called to reimagine not only *how* we teach and learn, but *why*. Artificial intelligence — undeniably one of the most consequential forces of the 21st century — presents us with a paradox: while it can accelerate access to knowledge and personalise learning experiences at scale, it also risks dehumanising education if reduced to metrics, automation, and passive consumption. The challenge before us is to resist simplistic binaries. The true question is not whether AI will shape the future of education — it already has — but whether we will shape *AI* in ways that honour and expand the deeper purposes of learning.

In this context, *Olympism* offers a profound and timely pedagogical counterbalance. Far from being confined to the realm of sport, Olympic values

represent an educational ethos—one that champions excellence not merely as performance, but as personal growth; that sees respect not as politeness, but as radical inclusivity; that defines fair play not as compliance, but as ethical leadership. This philosophy, rooted in both ancient wisdom and modern aspiration, is urgently needed as a moral compass in the age of intelligent machines.

What we propose, therefore, is the emergence of a *new Olympic pedagogy*: a pedagogical paradigm that is technologically literate, ethically grounded, culturally responsive, and humanistically inspired. This pedagogy does not view AI as a threat, nor as a panacea—but as a transformative partner in cultivating the intellectual, emotional, and moral capacities that define flourishing human beings.

Such a pedagogy requires a recalibration of educational goals. It invites us to teach *with* AI, not merely *about* it—to help students understand the logic of algorithms while nurturing their sense of wonder, discernment, and ethical agency. It calls upon educators to move beyond content delivery, becoming curators of authenticity, designers of inquiry, and facilitators of critical reflection. It encourages learners not simply to master knowledge, but to engage in *praxis*: the informed, conscious, and value-driven application of what they know to make the world more just, inclusive, and peaceful.

In practical terms, a new Olympic pedagogy must manifest across all levels of educational design:

In *curricula* that combine digital fluency with ethical reasoning and global citizenship.

In *assessment systems* that measure not only performance, but character, collaboration, and growth.

In *technological infrastructures* that prioritise transparency, accessibility, and participatory design.

In *educational leadership* that dares to articulate a vision of schooling that transcends mere productivity and speaks to purpose.

Crucially, this paradigm must be driven not solely by technologists or policymakers, but by educators—those who carry the sacred responsibility of shaping future generations. We must ensure that AI serves pedagogy, not the other way around.

In returning to the metaphor that opened this journey: education is a *relay*, a generational transmission of insight, courage, and hope. Artificial intelligence is not the runner, nor the torch—it is the *wind*, an unseen force that can propel

us forward, but only if guided by human hands and hearts. The torch – the light of wisdom, integrity, and empathy – remains irrevocably human.

Let us then move forward, not with fear, but with vision. Let us design and enact educational futures where digital intelligence is harmonised with human dignity, and where Olympic values are not remembered as distant ideals, but realised as everyday practice. In doing so, we will not only modernise education – we will elevate it.

Let us craft, together, a pedagogy that does not simply prepare learners for the future, but empowers them to *shape* it – wisely, ethically, and with the Olympic spirit burning bright.

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ESPORTS' PLACE WITHIN THE OLYMPIC MOVEMENT

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Introduction

Academic works and discussions on esports have increased in tandem with the economic importance of these activities. Numbers are presented to the readers and listeners to emphasise that esports is a serious *business*, not just a game. In our case, the facts that the International Olympic Committee (IOC), the supreme leader of the Olympic Movement, has been weighing the place of esports with the Movement since 2018, that the Olympic Esports Games will be held (for now) in 2027, and that we are here, are reasons enough for a discussion on esports.

In this lecture, I will focus on the Fundamental Principles of Olympism as outlined in the Olympic Charter and what they mean for esports' place within the Olympic Movement. Engaging in esports activities as players, consumers, and in other guises is currently a much-debated and relevant subject. The IOC has demonstrated its awareness of the growing societal interest and the financial opportunities that esports may offer. Nevertheless, certain aspects of the esports ecosystem, which includes various stakeholders ranging from esports players, teams, coaches, sponsors and audiences, do not fit well with the Fundamental Principles of Olympism. I will highlight some of the key issues regarding the intersection of the Olympic Movement, the Principles, and the *modus operandi* of esports. I will not raise the issue of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia being selected as the venue for the games or

the Esports World Cup Foundation, which is a component of the Kingdom's esports investment portfolio. Generally, I argue that one must first consider its disadvantages and the possible moral issues.

General Issues Regarding Esports

Esports competitions consist of contests based on video games between human players within organised and codified environments. One must consider the term video game in an expansive manner. That is, not only "computer games" but also games played on consoles, such as PlayStation, Xbox, and Nintendo Switch, as well as mobile games played on smartphones and tablets, are included within the definition. The expansive view of the landscape complicates matters in three regards: a) there are many video game titles, b) their developers and publishers may be different; and, c) esports competitions are based on video games of any genre, such as first-person shooters, third-person shooters, Multiplayer Online Battle Arena (MOBA for short), sports-themed games, and strategy games. *Tetris* can serve as the basis for esports competitions. Each of these points will constitute an essential point of discussion later.

At this point, the core issue with esports is that video games are "owned" by developers or publishers, as per intellectual property regimes and contracts that transfer the rights of individuals who create the games. Video games are a combination of software, sounds, images, and videos that fall under the umbrella of copyright. Likewise, innovative game mechanics can give rise to patents. Crucially, trademarks protect video game names, series or characters. The crux of the matter is that intellectual property rights, with certain exceptions, erect barriers to the use by non-owners of a creation, mark or innovation for a specific period. The owners have the say and power over their property. Intellectual property rights are exclusionary and anti-social.

The exclusionary ownership model, per Veli-Matti Karhulahti, can be called "executive ownership". Here, the "owner" of the video game title, which is generally the publisher, has strict and wide control over the product. It can publish a game and change its rules, structure and content. It can also discontinue it, as witnessed in the case of *Star Wars Galaxies*. Coupled with the idea that intellectual property rights are exclusionary, the owners can decide to keep the product to itself or "license" it to third parties. The term

third party also includes those who play the video game. Consumers do not "buy" the video game but acquire the "license" to play it. Essentially, no one except Nintendo or the companies or persons it licenses can create a video game called *Mario* and have moustachioed plumbers named Mario or Luigi as elements in their games. Likewise, no one can play the game without Nintendo's consent and license.

The Fragmented Nature of Esports Governance

Many video games can serve as the basis for esports competitions. You may have heard of the video games and series *Overwatch*, *League of Legends*, *Call of Duty* and the *EA Sports FC* series – formerly the FIFA series. However, there are also esports competitions based on other video games. *Tetris*, *World of Warships*, *Panzer Corps*, as well as mobile games like *Mobile Legends: Bang Bang* and *PUBG Mobile*, can become the sources of esports competitions. The latter two appeared in the 2023 Edition of the Southeast Asian Games.

The presence of many video games also brings about the issue of having many (if not an equal number) video game publishers. Parallel to the concept of executive ownership, these publishers aim to protect their interests and the games themselves. Accordingly, the creation of esports competitions or their support is at the behest of those who "own" the video games. A significant consequence of the executive ownership-driven video game and esports industries is that publishers, following their financial interests as corporations, do not come together to form esports associations or federations. Therefore, unlike sports, there are no monopolistic worldwide or continental esports federations. These kinds of esports federations only have the right to organise competitions if the owner licenses them the video game title.

Such a legal outlook has two consequences. First, the owner of a video game sets the rules of its commercialisation. It can decide to organise esports competitions to capitalise on the popularity of its video games. An outstanding example of this approach is the publisher Riot Games and its *League of Legends* competitions. The publisher has strict control over the competition structure, as well as the various aspects of commercialising these competitions. Owners may also decide not to organise esports competitions. In that case, third parties may choose to conduct the operations. Based on the license

acquired from the owner, amateur and local competitions may be held. Sometimes, the owners also allow third parties to organise competitions with small prize pools. More importantly, for this lecture, corporations like ESL FACEIT organise, supervise and regulate esports competitions.

Second, sports federations must collaborate or cooperate with the video game owners. Since they do not have intellectual property rights over the video game, they must acquire the consent of the owner to organise competitions. Of course, since the early days of mass video gaming, there have been collaborations between the Olympic Movement and the video game industry. Sports-themed video games have enjoyed licenses from international, continental and national sports federations, including the International Olympic Committee for Olympics-based video games. Yet, in the case of esports competitions, the relationship is reversed, as the international sports federations must acquire the consent of video game owners to organise or supervise esports competitions.

Some Issues Regarding the Interaction of the Olympic Movement and the Esports Ecosystem

I am not entering into a discussion on whether esports are sports or not. Here, I am more interested in the esports landscape's position vis-à-vis the Olympic Movement and the Fundamental Principles of Olympism appearing in the Olympic Charter.

The first practical issue surrounding the organisation of esports competitions under the remit of the Olympic Movement commences with the questions: who organises the event? Who has oversight over esports activities? Who has the regulatory, disciplinary and enforcement powers? These are important questions for the IOC and the Olympic Movement because the decisions taken to steer these activities impact how society and the market view them. Wrong decisions, poor structuring, and a general lack of perceived value would be detrimental to the Movement. Moreover, since the IOC is the supreme leader of the Movement, it must decide on the possible delegation of its powers to international sports federations or third parties. Essentially, the IOC and the elements of the Olympic Movement must decide whether esports activities will become a part of their structure.

One scenario involves hosting esports activities at arm's length and collaborating with the esports ecosystem when needed but refraining from directly organising and regulating esports competitions. The creation of the Olympic Esports Games rather than including them in the Olympic programme should be considered under this option. The second dimension concerns the control and oversight of esports competitions modelled after traditional sports. It includes the organisation of competitions and having regulatory, disciplinary and enforcement capabilities. A clear example of this approach is the recent addition of esports to FIFA's football-related powers. The FIFA Statutes, the constitutive document of the international governing body, now refers to esports.

The IOC's solution to the problem was to focus on the virtual versions of sports and collaborate with the esports ecosystem through these titles. The 8th IOC Olympic Summit signalled this approach by urging the Olympic Movement "[...] to consider how to govern electronic and virtual forms of their sport and explore opportunities with game publishers". The 2021 Olympic Virtual Series and the 2023 Olympic Esports Week reflected this by focusing solely on sports-themed games. On the organisation side, the IOC collaborates with the Esports World Cup Foundation. The Saudi Arabian entity, in turn, collaborates with ESL FACEIT, one of the leaders in third-party esports competition organisers.

Nevertheless, a hands-on approach may lead to power struggles with other institutions or corporations. In the case of Turkey, the status of football-themed esports activities and their governance became the centre of a struggle between the Turkish Football Federation and the Turkish Esports Federation. By law, the former has power over all football-related activities in Turkey, while the latter enjoys these powers regarding esports competitions. Therefore, the question was, should football-themed video games be considered as football or esports? The law favoured the Turkish Football Federation, which organises, regulates and presides over disciplinary processes for the eTurkish Cup, the eTurkish Super League and the eTurkish Super Cup.

Moral Issues

The Olympic Movement, the Olympic Games and Olympism are invariably

intertwined with moral stances. These stances include, among others, how the various elements of the Olympic Movement and participants should conduct themselves and should approach sport. This aspect is shaped by the Fundamental Principles of Olympism, which set out the core tenets of Olympism and the Olympic Games. They lay down the foundations of policies and core values of Olympism. They are prescriptive. Concerning the approach to sport, the obvious example is the Olympic Motto, "*Citius, Altius, Fortius – Communiter*". Striving to better oneself through contests while being part of the community, its rules and moral understanding are at the heart of these four words.

The fundamental challenge against these morals-laden statements and rules comes from the fact that video games are based on intellectual property. If the Olympic Movement considers esports a type of sporting activity, it must adhere to the Fourth Fundamental Principle of Olympism, which emphasises that sport is a human right. Human rights are universalistic and inclusive; therefore, they align with the universalism of Olympism. Moreover, human rights are not only manifesto-like, but they also provide moral or legal barriers against the negative impact of states, society, and markets on individuals and groups. The Olympic Movement's stance on political and economic intervention in sports parallels these aspects of human rights.

On the other hand, like other property rights, intellectual property rights, which undergird video games and esports, are exclusionary. Unlike sports activities, one must obtain a license to play the game, whether in single-player mode or multiplayer mode, at local, amateur, or global levels. Therefore, commercial activity is a prerequisite for esports competitions. One cannot practice a human right to sport without it. The legal landscape also concerns the Sixth Fundamental Principle, which stipulates that property cannot be used as a tool for discrimination within the Olympic Movement. Again, the intellectual property and licensing regimes serve as discriminatory tools. Finally, the video game itself – the basis of esports – is detrimental to the "together" part of the Olympic Motto. Intellectual property regimes and their exclusionary role can stop people from coming together.

In the previous parts, I emphasised the fact that there are various genres of video games, including shooters and strategy games. The IOC is aware of the issue as it decided not to engage with first-person and third-person shooters due to their being violent. Thomas Bach expressly indicated that "killergames", where violent actions can occur and avatars can get "killed",

have no place within the Olympic Movement. Although blood can be optional for some titles, the destruction of one's avatar and the possible impact of virtual violence on individuals have been the leading detractors in ruling out shooters. The IOC's focus on the virtual versions of sports solidified this stance. Essentially, this adheres to the Second Fundamental Principle of Olympism, which highlights human dignity, peace, and the harmonious development of humankind.

Nevertheless, there are three salient issues. First, what does the term "violence" include? Shooter games are primarily designed to harm opponents by targeting them. The more complicated genres are strategy and fighting. In strategy games with the ultimate purpose of winning by destroying the opponents, the player does not "shoot" at the enemies but instead orders the avatars to attack or defend against other avatars. Without delving into the "speech act" theory of Searle, I emphasise that for Olympism, ordering to destroy is as problematic as doing so. In both cases, the aim of the game is destruction. Fighting games also have a violence problem. In these games, players generally fight individually through avatars against one another. The moves and hits, as well as special powers, talents and capabilities, are stylised, and so is the violence. In a social, legal and moral landscape where even the Olympic sport of boxing has its detractors, stylised violence in a virtual world should be considered on the same terms as shooters/"killergames".

Second, although strategy and fighting games are not a part of the competitions presided over by the IOC, there have been exhibition esports matches based on them. Before the PyeongChang Winter Olympic Games in 2018, the Intel Extreme Masters esports tournament was based on *StarCraft II*, a real-time strategy game. In this genre, all avatars move at the same time, rather than taking turns, as in chess. Likewise, *Street Fighter 6* was one of the titles introduced as exhibition events at the 2023 Olympic Esports Week. Therefore, one way or another, the IOC, through its licensing of the title "Olympic", has some kind of association with violent video games. Consequently, a more consistent approach is necessary.

Third, the Olympic Movement is a wide-ranging term. Officially, it includes organisations, athletes and other persons guided by the Olympic Charter. However, at its most basic, it consists of the IOC, international sports federations and the national Olympic committees. A critical view of organisations and sports governing bodies, such as the latter two, is necessary

for our purposes. The reason is that the various elements of the Movement may hold differing views on the place of esports within it. As I mentioned above, the IOC's relationship with the esports ecosystem is complex. Esports is neither within nor outside the Movement. On the other hand, the Olympic Council of Asia, which organises the Asian Games, has a different view of the situation. At the 2026 Asian Games, medal events for esports will include shooters such as *Naraka: Bladepoint* and *PUBG: Mobile*, as well as *Identity V*, a horror-survival game. Of course, the moral outlook of every element of the Olympic Movement, as well as the organisers, cannot be the same. Yet, to consider esports' place within the Olympic Movement, one also expects transparency, consistency, and foreseeability.

Final Thoughts

As you may have noticed, in my discussion of the issues with esports' place within the Olympic Movement, I did not suggest whether esports *should* be included in the first place. Although I am a gamer, I remain neutral for now. However, that does not mean that one, and especially the IOC, should not be critical of esports, its nature, foundations and *modus operandi*. My discussion revolved around this idea. Before associating, collaborating, or cooperating with any entity, industry, or institution, the Olympic Movement must adopt a holistic and critical perspective on them. Esports may be getting popular, and the financial opportunities may (in theory) not be negligible, but the consequences of embracing it should be mapped out.

Furthermore, the Olympic Movement, and the IOC as its leader, must be consistent in their dealings with the esports ecosystem. I underlined that the choice of video game titles and genres is correct and fair. Violent video games are not fit for the Movement. On the other hand, I also pointed out that the scope of the term violence is debatable. Likewise, the fact that the Olympic Movement comprises many sports governing bodies makes a consistent approach more challenging to achieve. Ultimately, I consistently referred to intellectual property regimes as the foundation of the esports ecosystem. Accordingly, the IOC, despite enjoying its intellectual property rights, should consider if these rights contradict the Fundamental Principles of Olympism. In particular, access to video games and esports as participants

is a serious concern. Consequently, despite the rapid rise of esports and the IOC's relatively quick embrace of these activities, the Olympic Movement and we, as educators, must continuously analyse whether the next steps are tenable and if things are going in the right direction.

NEUROSTIMULATION: THE EMERGENCE OF NEW TECHNOLOGIES IN TRADITIONAL SPORT AND ESPORTS¹

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Thank you for the introduction, and thank you to everyone involved in organising this event. It's been a wonderful experience so far, and I'm honoured to speak with you today.

My talk will focus on expertise — how the brain supports it, how expertise develops, and how performance improves over time.

We'll begin with a brief history of technology in Olympic sport. Then we'll explore emerging technologies designed to enhance the athlete's brain. I'll present evidence for their effectiveness in both traditional sport and esports, and conclude with the controversial topic of neurostimulation and its potential role in neurodoping.

When we look back at the first Olympic Games in 1896, there was virtually no technology — just stopwatches. In 1912, the photo-finish camera was introduced, and by 1964 electronic timing systems and starting blocks were standard in sprinting.

The 1970s and 1980s marked the digital revolution, with touchpads on pool walls, video playback, and wind tunnel testing. In the 1990s and 2000s, biomechanical and physiological monitoring arrived: heart rate monitors, motion capture, and advanced analysis tools to evaluate and optimise performance.

The 2010s and 2020s saw the rise of smart fabrics and wearable

1. This is the transcript of Prof. Adam Toth's lecture presentation during the Session.

technology. At the 2024 Paris Olympic Games, AI-assisted judging and real-time performance data became available to athletes during competition.

This history shows that almost all sports technologies have targeted the body – improving movement, strength, endurance – while comparatively few have focused on the brain.

So before we get into neurostimulation, let's look at how the brain actually learns new skills.

Take Steph Curry, arguably the most prolific three-point shooter in basketball history. He practices about 500 shots a day, making his movements appear fluid and automatic – hallmarks of expertise.

But how does this expertise develop?

When you throw a ball, your brain first draws on memory traces from past attempts, involving areas like the frontal lobe and hippocampus. These memories activate sequences of neurons that form what's called a *motor programme*. Think of it like entering a button combination in a video game: the correct sequence leads to success; the wrong one leads to failure.

The motor cortex, a band of tissue running ear to ear across the top of your head, executes the motor programme. Neurons there send signals down the spinal cord to muscles which control your movement.

When you throw the ball, sensory feedback follows: your eyes see if you hit the target, your skin and muscles provide feedback on stretch and pressure. The brain then compares this actual feedback with the expected feedback predicted by the motor programme.

If the two match, the brain reinforces the chosen motor programme. If they don't, the resulting error signal weakens that programme, making the brain more likely to select a different one next time.

Through repeated practice, the brain probabilistically refines motor programmes – reducing the chance of selecting poor ones, increasing the chance of selecting effective ones.

At the cellular level, when two neurons fire together repeatedly, their connection strengthens – this is Hebbian learning: *neurons that fire together wire together*. Stronger connections form through more receptors at the receiving neuron and additional branching between neurons.

Where does neurostimulation fit in?

Neurostimulation involves passing small electrical currents over the scalp to influence brain activity. At a super-threshold level, neurons can be directly

activated. At a sub-threshold level, they aren't triggered to fire, but become more sensitive and more likely to fire.

The type I'll discuss today is sub-threshold stimulation, often called *neuropriming*. For example, applying a small current over the motor cortex makes a target neuron more responsive to incoming signals. Each time its partner neuron fires, the target fires more easily, accelerating the strengthening of their connection. In essence, neurostimulation speeds up the brain's natural learning process.

How does this look in practice?

In a 2023 taekwondo study, athletes who received neurostimulation before training showed reduced reaction times and fewer errors compared to a placebo group.

In golf, a 2024 study demonstrated increased clubhead speed and driving distance after stimulation — two of the strongest predictors of success on the PGA Tour. Even professional golfers like Charlie Hoffman have adopted this technology, using headsets like the Halo device.

Turning to esports:

Esports demand fine motor skills, especially in first-person shooter games. One key skill is *target acquisition* — the rapid detection and elimination of an opponent. Research in our lab has shown that performance on a custom target acquisition test can reliably distinguish between non-gamers, low-skill gamers, and high-skill gamers.

In a training study in our lab, players were divided into three groups: no stimulation, sham stimulation (placebo), and real stimulation. After five days of identical training, the stimulation group improved significantly more, with roughly a 12% performance advantage. Interestingly, the benefits were especially strong for lower-skilled players.

We've also tested this in simulated racing, using full cockpit rigs. Again, after several days of training, both placebo and stimulation groups improved, but the stimulation group showed faster lap times — improvements of 5–6 seconds, which is huge in motorsport. Importantly, these gains persisted after several days of rest, indicating lasting learning effects.

So, what about neurodoping?

According to the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA), a method can be banned if it meets two of three criteria:

1. It enhances performance.

2. It poses health risks.
3. It violates the spirit of sport.

Evidence from taekwondo, golf, and cycling suggests that neurostimulation can enhance performance, at least in some contexts. So criterion one is satisfied.

Health risks, however, appear minimal. A 2016 review covering 33,000 sessions across 1,000 participants—including children and elderly adults—found no serious adverse effects. Neurostimulation is considered safe and non-invasive. So criterion two is not met.

Does it violate the spirit of sport? The spirit is defined by factors such as safety, fairness, accessibility, and the need for hard work. Neurostimulation requires training to be effective—you can't just apply a current and instantly improve. Devices are increasingly accessible, ranging from €100 to €700, and may even reduce the gap between novices and experts by accelerating early skill development.

By these standards, neurostimulation does not appear to violate the spirit of sport.

CYBERCULTURE, CYBERSPACE AND THE OLYMPIC MOVEMENT

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1. Introduction

Dear Fellow Participants of the 15th International Session for Educators of Higher Institutes of Physical Education, it is an honour to be here talking to you about this topic, something that I have been studying in depth since the end of 2017, when I founded the Center for Studies in Electronic Games and Esports, and began teaching an elective course on this topic at my university. These actions were pioneering in Brazil, which gave us a very interesting path. It is worth mentioning that I am also an esports athlete; I participate in virtual motorsport competitions. I say this because this fact allows me to have an inside view of this phenomenon, putting me in a privileged position to carry out these studies.

Electronic games are relatively recent. In this period of just over 70 years since their first appearance, we can observe several distinct characteristics which are directly related to technological development over time, and which will be the subject of analysis in this text. To facilitate the historical understanding of these different phases, we will present here the periodisation proposal that we are developing.

Before we begin this analysis, we need to make it clear that we understand “electronic games” as “games”, that is, they are played by people in unique situations. Games are not static, they are constantly being recreated and developed, as is their gameplay. The way of playing the same game is always

changing. No two games are the same, or even, you don't play a game the same way twice.

This characteristic of creating, reproducing and transmitting makes it an important cultural element. With the advent of online gaming, the appropriation of this creation becomes multicultural, where players come into contact with other players anywhere in the world with different views of the same phenomenon interacting in the same place.

As noted, it is this playful basis that permeates this entire process, and which, at the same time, is undergoing a great transformation in its traditional way of manifesting itself. I am not saying here that this change is good or bad, but rather that it is a change and that we need to understand it.

These characteristics mentioned above are related to the human imagination, as they only make sense to those who are inserted within its dynamics, and can therefore be characterised as cultural production. In general, we understand that culture is everything that is not transmitted genetically, that is, the entire universe of creation, transmission and appropriation of symbolisms (speech, writing, body behaviours...), and that it is through the imagination that these symbolic representations gain meaning.

And as expected, playfulness as a cultural production accompanied the technological development of humanity. Right at the beginning of the technological era, while the first computers were being created and developed, the first forms of playful approaches to technology also began to appear. From then on, a direct relationship was established between technology and playfulness, which expanded in meanings and possibilities, becoming an important sociocultural manifestation. Although its competitive form has been present practically since its first appearances, it was only at the turn of the century that the inevitable approach to the sports structure appeared, generating several discussions, such as about the possibilities of esports actually being a sport, which ended up attracting the attention of large entities, such as the International Olympic Committee.

As we can see, electronic games present distinct characteristics from different historical moments, which is what we will analyse next.

2. The periodisation proposal

The proposal for periodisation occurs when it is possible to observe distinct characteristics in specific periods of time. Through it, we can organise the temporal intervals, interpreting them based on the context in which the events were produced.

Electronic games, by definition, are a form of game in which the player interacts with an electronic device through peripherals connected to a specific device. They emerged in the middle of the last century, the initial milestone accepted by the literature dates back more precisely to 1947, with the development of the “cathode ray tube amusement device”.

It is important to mention this, because the 20th century was marked by a series of technological innovations. From radio to personal microcomputers that connect us to any place in the world in real time, several stages were reached, each of them accompanied by creative use by human beings. With each advancement, there is a slow process of discovery of its specificities, culminating in a rapid period of transformation of its possibilities, accelerating changes, improving quality, which may have been incomprehensible at that time. It is precisely this scenario that will take us to the next generation. Nicolau Sevcenko calls this process the “*roller coaster loop*”, which has a slow rise and a dizzying fall.

Therefore, given their characteristics, electronic games are directly related to the situation mentioned above. Several “loops” have already been gone through, and we will try to analyse each of them from now on.

2.1. Experimentation

The first forms of recreational approaches to electronic equipment did not have any major objectives; they were merely technological “tricks” that transformed a device for a specific purpose into a playful manifestation. This was what happened in 1947, when an oscilloscope was transformed into a “cathode ray tube amusement device”. A few years later, in 1958, the famous “*Tennis for Two*” was also created using an oscilloscope, which is often considered the precursor of all electronic games given that its gameplay required not only an electronic device but also a peripheral.

In any case, these initial approaches were still in the realm of experimenta-

tion, that is, human creativity was still experimenting with what these new devices could do beyond the obvious use for which they were originally designed.

From this new possibility, several attempts to create games appeared throughout the 50s and 60s. The game “*Spacewar!*” developed by the Massachusetts Institute of Technology in 1961 is a good example of this movement. Created specifically to test the possibilities of a new type of computer, the game was quite successful within the small community of programmers at the time, went through different versions and in 1972 was responsible for the first competition involving an electronic device on record, the “Intergalactic Spacewar Olympics”, held at Stanford University. This is one of the most important games in history, being the oldest to enter the “Video Game Hall of Fame”.

Technological development facilitated access to this equipment, which then began to be made exclusively for playing the game, leaving specialised laboratories and being able to be played by a greater number of people.

2.2 Exploration

The second phase is marked by the emergence of “Arcade Videogames”. Their main feature is to integrate the game system with the monitor and controls in a specific cabinet, which became known as “arcades”. Unlike their predecessors, these new games did not require an expensive and specific computer to be played, they depended on a relatively cheap system, which facilitated the possibility of commercial use.

Although the first machine with this feature was the “Space Computer”, based on the gameplay of “*Spacewar!*” in 1971, the game that marked the beginning of this new phase was “*Pong*”, developed by the newly founded Atari in 1972, the simple gameplay of which meant “*anyone drunk at any bar could play*”. The huge success of this formula led to other games being developed, exploring not only this new market, but also this new technological possibility. Costing just a quarter of a dollar to play, the revenue continued to grow as new games appeared. Among them, “*Pac-Man*” was one of the biggest hits and still leads this list today, having raised around 20 billion dollars in adjusted values.

It wasn’t long before it became possible to play these games at home

using specific devices, known as "consoles". In general, the main objective of these games was to score the highest possible number of points based on the proposed challenge. With this dynamic, Atari organised the first large-scale championship that we know of in 1981, the "Space Invaders Championship", attended by approximately 10,000 people, and won by a woman, Rebecca Ann Heineman.

With the advent of the console in which it was possible to exchange "cartridges", the first developers began to appear and began to compete with Atari in the market by releasing new games at a speed greater than the public could absorb. The unbridled exploitation of this new possibility caused games to remain "stranded" on store shelves, which led to the "video game crash of 1983" and the end of the "Golden Age of Arcades" in 1984. The excess of games, many of them of low quality, without offering anything different in their gameplay, caused consumers to lose confidence in this type of entertainment. The production of the game *"ET the Extra-Terrestrial"* marked the downfall of Atari. The low-quality game with terrible gameplay sold poorly and its excess was apparently buried. What was just an urban legend turned out to be true with the "discovery" and subsequent excavation of the site in Alamogordo, New Mexico, in 2014, documented in the film *"Atari: Game Over"*.

2.3 Imagination

The 1983 crisis was "saved" by the emergence of Nintendo's video game console, which brought better quality games than the previous generation and introduced a new element to the gameplay: the story. This allowed the emergence of characters with great emotional connotation, such as Mario Bros. The saga to rescue Princess Peach from the clutches of Bowser gained much more space in the imagination of players than the story actually occupied within the game, which was in reality quite simple.

Several other games with similar characteristics appeared throughout this phase, and along with them, a new way of producing culture also began to appear. These characters, belonging to a virtual environment, began to gain strong enough meanings and significance to make them leave the environment in which they would be "confined".

The formula worked. Nintendo continued to produce its games and

develop its consoles, seeking to establish this connection with its players. In the same way, competing companies appeared, first Sega and then Sony, which followed the same dynamic. As technology advanced, the graphic quality improved and the stories became more intense. Little by little, it became possible for us to interfere in the gameplay, modifying our gaming experience according to our own desires. It was already an attempt to “enter” the virtual environment, exploring what we would later know as “cyberspace”.

Games at this stage were still played locally, players had to be in the same physical location to interact in the same game. However, during the act of playing, the imagination amplifies momentary experiences, giving them a much greater meaning than those that are actually being produced. In this way, players did not need to be in the same place to share their experiences. Even with the video game turned off, the characters remained active in people’s imaginations. This situation is called immaterial culture, which is essential for the creation of a group with its own identity.

And thus the gamer community would emerge, which would consolidate itself in the next phase.

2.4 Interaction

Shortly before the turn of the century, the Internet became part of humanity’s daily life, and along with it came the concept of “Cyberspace”, which, in the words of Pierre Lévy, is defined as the “communication space opened up by the worldwide interconnection of computers and computer memories”. The concept of cyberspace itself actually first appeared in 1984 in the novel *Neuromancer* by William Gibson, which even served as inspiration for the directors of *The Matrix* to create its story. More recently, the film *Wreck-It Ralph* explored this theme, taking the exploration of cyberspace to a children’s universe.

From this stage on, players would no longer need to be physically in the same place to interact with each other in the same game. In real time, people from different parts of the world share the same experience, developing what we call “cyberculture”, also defined by Lévy as “the set of techniques (material and intellectual), practices, attitudes, ways of thinking and values that develop together with the growth of cyberspace”.

This phase sees a major transformation in the interaction between people; games and online environments bring a new reality. People in different

places, with different characteristics and different stories, can interact within cyberspace without carrying any of the characteristics of “real life”, without the “labels” that are often placed on people in face-to-face meetings. This new possibility of multicultural construction based on the interaction established by the virtual environment is what we call “cyber multiculturalism”.

Another great feature of this phase is the possibility of playing without having the game itself. We no longer need consoles, cartridges, discs or any other specific form of physical media. With “cloud gaming”, from an electronic device connected to the Internet, it is now possible to access a gigantic collection of online games in a way that would have been unimaginable until recently. Thus, the interaction established in this phase is not only between players, but also between the community of each game and its developers, making it possible to observe user behaviour, make specific updates and often explore attractive forms of monetisation, such as “loot boxes” and “season passes”.

From this stage onwards, the gaming community consolidated itself. It overcame prejudices, deconstructed stereotypes and moved forward to interact with other social manifestations, such as sports.

2.5 Competition

Even though competitive forms involving electronic games were present practically since their beginning, it was only after the massification of the Internet that the first specific institutions for sports organisation appeared.

From the timid emergence of the “Cyberathlete Professional League” (CPL) in 1997 to the announcement of the creation of the Esports Olympic Games in 2024, a long way has been travelled, including the definition and acceptance of the term “electronic sport” or just “esports” as we know it.

What is considered the first professional tournament was held in 1997 by Id Software, called “Red Annihilation”, and the prize was a Ferrari that belonged to John Carmack, one of the company’s founders. This event, along with the emergence of the CPL, led to the popularisation of the term “cyber athlete” at the same time that the foundations for the development of electronic sports were being formed.

At practically the same time, the Asian continent saw the number of players and enthusiasts increase significantly, which favoured the emergence of the

“Korean e-sports Association”, which was responsible for creating the term “esports”, by promoting its regulation in a similar way to traditional sports. The rapid growth from this led to the creation of professional leagues and the emergence of major tournaments, such as the “World Cyber Games” (2000) and the “Electronic Sports World Cup” (2003).

Next up, games like *League of Legends*, *Dota 2*, and *Counter-Strike* have led to competitions being broadcast live on platforms such as Twitch and YouTube, attracting millions of viewers. The popularity of esports and the dedication of their players to both game strategies and their personal physical preparation to endure the many hours of training and competitions has sparked a discussion about their recognition and inclusion in the Olympic programme.

3. Approaching the Olympic Movement

The International Olympic Committee (IOC) quickly recognised the importance of electronic games for the rejuvenation of the Olympic Movement, one of the pillars of Agenda 2020. During the 7th Olympic Summit in 2018, the “Esports Liaison Group” was created, and later that year the “Esports Forum” was organised at the Olympic Museum in Lausanne, aiming to build a platform for future engagement and to highlight opportunities for cooperation. During the event, it became clear that the lack of a global organisation for esports that could align with the Olympic system and values was a significant obstacle to the inclusion of these sports in the Olympic Games. During the 8th Olympic Summit, the potential of sports simulations was highlighted and sports federations were further encouraged to control the electronic versions of their sports.

In 2021, with the publication of Agenda 2020+5, two new recommendations that directly involve electronic games emerged: Recommendation 8 – “Increase digital engagement with people”, and mainly Recommendation 9 – “Encourage the development of virtual sports and further interact with video game communities”. However, the inclusion of esports in the Olympic Games still faces significant challenges. The main concern is to align these competitions with Olympic values, such as respect and fair play, in addition to addressing issues related to the violence that some games bring, such as first-person shooters.

In 2021, the need for social isolation caused by the pandemic caused the number of players to grow significantly, and in this context, the IOC showed real interest in this discussion by organising an esports event shortly before the Tokyo Olympic Games, the “Olympic Virtual Series”. Although it was not an official part of the Tokyo Olympic Games that same year, this event demonstrated the IOC’s willingness to explore its inclusion. This first contact took place predominantly online, but two years later the “Olympic Esports Week” was held in Singapore, an event with the finals held entirely in person, contributing to the consolidation of the rapprochement between esports and the Olympic Movement. The announcement made during the 142nd IOC Session of the creation of the Esports Olympic Games, which were to be held in Saudi Arabia from 2025 onwards, and later postponed to 2027, is still the biggest step that esports will need to take to definitively consolidate itself.

4. Final Considerations

We can see, then, that electronic games are a playful manifestation of modernity, resulting from the characteristics of the technological advances of our time. Their competitive form has been structured until it is “serious” enough to be, in fact, considered a sporting practice. Their rapprochement with the Olympic Movement is only just beginning. The inclusion of the theme in the 2020+5 Olympic Agenda demonstrates the IOC’s effort to adapt to cultural and technological changes.

The announcement of the creation of the Esports Olympic Games, just six years after the first official mention, represents a surprisingly rapid strategic approach by the Olympic Movement. However, the gap between the games chosen for the first events held and the most popular titles in the real competitive esports scene reflects the tension between tradition and modernisation. Their inclusion as part of the Olympic Programme seems unlikely in the short term, however, the creation of the Esports Olympic Games was a major step in building a stronger relationship between the IOC and the global gaming community.

ESPORTS DIPLOMACY AND THE NEW ERA OF THE OLYMPIC MOVEMENT

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Introduction

The esports industry generates billions of dollars worldwide, with the United States and China being the dominant markets. The money is there, the youth is there, the global outreach is there, and many professional sports leagues have created virtual product extensions to capitalise on the growing gaming market. In fact, international multi-sports events are also there, with the Asian Games also adding esports as medal events in 2023. And just as with traditional sports, with money, ratings, and international exposure, countries, cities, and communities, are bound to try and capitalise on esports to leverage their image to achieve social, economic, and political goals. In all reality, the International Olympic Committee needs esports more than esports needs the International Olympic Committee (IOC).

The IOC was not oblivious to the rise of esports. Although there are several obstacles that prevent esports becoming medal events in the Olympic Movement, such as popular titles being about war, and especially the lack of evident physical activity, over the past decade, there have been ample intersections between virtual gaming and the Olympic Movement. These range from a comic segment in the passing of the flag ceremony in the 2016 Rio de Janeiro Olympic Games when the late Japanese Prime Minister came into the

Maracana Stadium dressed as Super Mario, through exhibitions around the Lausanne 2020 Winter Youth Olympic Games, to recommendations in the Olympic Agenda 2020+5, establishing the Olympic Esports Series and the Olympic Esports Week in 2023 and, in 2024, and announcing the creation of the Olympic Esports Games, with the first editions hosted in Saudi Arabia.

The Olympic Games are the largest and most global event, which the world holds peacefully with over 200 countries and delegations participating and raising their flags in the opening ceremony. That is more than the number of official member states in the United Nations. With the Olympic Games broadcast globally, this creates nation branding and sports diplomacy, with opportunities for countries, communities, and people to leverage the exposure to improve their images and to achieve social, economic, and political goals. One of the ways to do so is through technological advancements, such as sport-tech diplomacy. Esports, gaming, or any other form of virtual competitions, are part of the sport-tech ecosystem. This presentation discusses the intersection between esports, diplomacy, and the Olympic Movement, through the lens of sport-tech diplomacy.

Sport-Tech Diplomacy

- **Soft power:** The ability to shape preferences of others and get them to do what you want through attraction without the use of payments or of military force. The three main resources of soft power are: (a) culture, (b) political values, and (c) foreign policy.

- **Traditional Public diplomacy:** Communications and interactions by governments, policymakers, organisations, and individuals to influence the public in foreign countries to achieve a more favourable image of the nation and ultimately achieve foreign policy goals.

- **Contemporary definitions** also focus on other aspects of diplomacy such as corporate diplomacy, and people-to-people diplomacy, cultural diplomacy, or sports diplomacy that can shape the image of a country.

- **Country image:** “the total sum of all perceptions of a nation in the minds of international stakeholders, which may contain some of the following elements: people, place, culture / language, history, food, fashion, famous faces (celebrities), global brands and so on” (Fan, 2010, p. 98). Country image

is one of the outcomes of nation branding, which is impacted by political branding such as public diplomacy, export branding such as product-country-image or country-of-origin, place branding such as tourism destination image, and cultural branding through national identity. Buhmann and Ingenhoff (2015), use a four-dimensional country image model, analysing the image of a country through the functional, normative, aesthetic, and sympathetic dimensions.

- Sport-tech diplomacy: the intersection between sports, technology, and diplomacy. Esports is considered part of the sport-tech ecosystem.

The Case of Israel

- Attempts to bypass the negative impact of the dispute through the branding of Israel as “Start-Up Nation” and “Land of Creation”.

- Different Israeli stakeholders manage to differentiate themselves through focusing on sports-technology. Through traditional public diplomacy, people-to-people diplomacy, and corporate diplomacy and despite the deteriorating image of the country, Israeli companies and people manage to engage in the most significant sports organisations in the world, which see value collaborating with Israeli industry despite international critics and calls for boycotts.

- Example: IntelliGym uses a technology developed for Israeli air force pilots that trains athletes’ cognitive abilities in split-second decision making. Among the clients are sports clubs from Germany, the Netherlands, Belgium, Hockey Canada, and a variety of Division I American universities.

- Israel’s sport-tech diplomacy was mostly effective in peaceful times, yet when the conflict escalates, especially since October 7 and the following wars, geopolitics, and the security situation often overshadow Israel’s ability to bypass the polarising conflict.

The Case of Japan and the Olympic Movement

- Using the Tokyo 1964 Olympic Games to reposition its image from the hawkish Imperial country in World War II to a global technological innovator, including through the introduction of technologies and the bullet train.

- **Cool Japan:** A nation branding attempt to attract younger audiences through focusing on Japanese culture including anime, manga, cartoons, and video games as many of the leading companies such as SEGA, SONY, and Nintendo are from Japan.
- **Tokyo 2020** was supposed to be a celebration of esports. In the handing of the flag ceremony in the Rio de Janeiro 2016 Olympic Games Closing Ceremony, the late Japanese Prime Minister, Shinzo Abe, entered the Maracana Stadium from a pipe, dressed as the beloved video game character Super Mario.
- **Changing narratives** following the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic. Due to the ongoing state of emergency Tokyo and Japan were facing in 2021, and the decline in public opinion of the postponed Olympic Games, many Japanese companies toned down their involvement and attempts to capitalise on the event as a global celebration. The references to esports were minimal, with delegations entering the Olympic Stadium in the Opening Ceremony to the music of familiar video games.

Esports Diplomacy and the International Olympic Committee

- One of the key five pillars of Agenda 2020+5 was digitalisation. According to the IOC, during the pandemic the gaming industry saw a 30% growth in gamers and a 75% growth in gaming usage, and in 2020 was worth 159 billion USD.
- Recommendation #9 of the 15 recommendations included in Agenda 2020+5 was to “Encourage the development of virtual sports and further engage with video gaming communities” (International Olympic Committee, 2023, p. 2). One of the subsections even suggested to “consider the addition of physical virtual sports in the Olympic Programme in cooperation with the respective IFs” (International Olympic Committee, 2023, p. 21). In the background to the recommendations the IOC explains:

Video games are bringing communities together with people gathering around their passion. By entering strategic partnerships with those communities at a regional level, sports organisations can reach youth demographics outside of their direct environment and get these youth engaged in sport while reaching out to new

populations (International Olympic Committee, 2023, p. 22).

- 2018-2024: East Asia was both a hub for esports and for the Olympic Movement, with the Winter Olympic Games in PyeongChang (South Korea) and Beijing (China), the Olympic Games in Tokyo (Japan), the Winter Youth Olympic Games in Gangwon (South Korea), and the Olympic Esports Week in Singapore. In 2018, former Worldwide TOP Partner Intel, held esports tournaments in PyeongChang and Beijing, including an exhibition featuring the official licensed PyeongChang 2018 video game in what was framed as “Steep Road to the Olympics” (IOC News, 2017).

- Singapore, which hosted the first Youth Olympic Games in 2010, had another breakthrough moment in the Olympic Movement, hosting the Olympic Esports Week in 2023, featuring virtual sports in archery, baseball, chess, cycling, dance, motor sport, sailing, shooting, taekwondo, and tennis (Olympic Esports Series, n.d.). By focusing on satellite events such as the Youth Olympic Games and the Olympic Esports Week, Singapore demonstrated that a small country can manage to create value with the Olympic Movement and position itself as a global innovator.

- Other esports engagements: Esports exhibitions during the Lausanne 2020 Winter Olympic Games around The Olympic Capital and the use of video games in Olympic Houses during Paris 2024. For example, Slovak House in Parc de la Villette featured a cycling simulator exemplifying the connection between technology, outdoor culture, physical activity, sustainability, and the scenery of the country.

- Olympic Esports Games: IOC selected Saudi Arabia to host the first editions of the Olympic Esports Games. That will be another step in the country’s use of sports for soft power after establishing LIV Golf, hosting annual WWE events, buying Newcastle United, local football clubs signing worldclass players such as Cristiano Ronaldo and being awarded the FIFA World Cup in 2034. This will give the IOC a chance to evaluate its relationship with Saudi Arabia, including addressing any rising criticism.

Conclusion

The new era of the Olympic Movement is very much defined by a pragmatic approach as manifested through the “change or be changed” philosophy of

Thomas Bach, including making significant changes to what was perceived as keeping old traditions. The IOC recognises the worldwide growth of esports and their popularity among youth. With more countries involved and trying to capitalise on this, nation branding and public diplomacy also play a role, especially with the growing emphasis on technology. The past decade and a half showed that there are cultural diplomacy opportunities in esports and that the IOC is looking for product extensions beyond just hosting Olympic Games. Los Angeles is an esports capital in the USA, and Australia is one of the leading countries in sports-technologies. So, it will not be surprising if, in the future, there are some cultural diplomacy references to gaming as well. So, where are things heading from here? The Olympic Esports Games give the IOC the chance to answer some of these questions, along with evaluating Saudi Arabia's interest in being more involved with the Olympic Movement. Esports diplomacy is a much more direct pathway for more involvement in the Olympic Games through hosting the Olympic Esports Games. Probably not soon, but in the changing nature of the new era of the Olympic Movement, never say never.

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THE TYRANNY OF QUANTIFICATION: RETHINKING THE FUTURE OF OLYMPIC SPORT

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The title of my presentation is a provocative one, suggesting that quantification in sport may function as a dominant, even oppressive force. But what does it mean to speak of a tyranny of quantification in sport? And why is it important to talk about this?

In Allen Guttman's (1978) book, *From Ritual to Record*, he identified quantification as one of the main characteristics of modern sport. Quantification refers not only to the tendency to measure every athletic performance in quantitative terms, but also to the desire to "set a record" or "to break a record". In modern sport, this is not only one characteristic of sport, but is now one of the dominant ways to approach it. In today's sporting world, everything is measured: human movements are timed to the millisecond, bodies are reduced to data, and graphs, sensors, and algorithms guide training programmes. Sport has become a realm where every athletic action is viewed primarily through the lens of quantification. This approach was, indeed, criticised by Coubertin when he noted that the:

Current educational philosophy, in its obstinate error, has made the present generations stray into the impasse of excessive specialization, where they will find nothing but obscurity and disunity. They believe they are very powerful because they have great appetites, and they believe they are very wise because they have a great deal of scientific data. In reality, they are poorly prepared for the troubles

ahead. Intelligence is smothered by knowledge, critical minds are debased by an overwhelming mass of facts, and adolescents are trained into the mentality of the anthill, surrounded by the artificial and the accepted, with categories and statistics, a fetish for numbers, an unhealthy search for detail and the exception (in Müller 2000: 559).

In this presentation, I would like to take a step back and reconsider some of the most basic assumptions that structure our understanding of sport. I contend that the quantitative approach that dominates sport is tyrannical because it presents not only a one-way view of understanding sport, but also a potential threat to Olympism. I argue that this approach obscures Olympism's ideas of balance of "body, will, and mind" and its goal "to create a way of life based on the joy of effort", highlighted in the first Fundamental Principle of Olympism. I argue this because recently the cases of athlete burnout, loss of motivation, emotional stress, and dropout – which directly contradict the first Fundamental Principle – can be traced back to the most dominant way of understanding sport: quantification.

To do so, I believe, it is fair to recover the works of the New Marxist theorists of sport because their insights might help us to re-evaluate the current sportive and sportive-academic landscapes. These scholars saw sport as a repressive force and a practice that serves the interests of capitalism, basing their claims on noting that sports are identical to labour, and through sports, humans internalise work-like behaviours as dictated by the imperative of production (Rigauer, 1981; Brohm, 1976, 1978; Beamish, 1981, 1985; Carrington & McDonald, 2008). The New Marxist theorists, of course, following the lead of Marx, who argued that labour is the "life of the species," have placed labour at the forefront of their investigations. Their justification to address sport from a labour-directed perspective is that sport not only takes place in capitalist societies where the logic of labour (efficiency and productivity) is present in all aspects of human life, but also because sport and labour resemble one another.

For instance, they say that the rules of sport possess the same productive apparatus of capitalist societies: achievement principles, competition, quantification, and normative standards of conduct; as well as the modes of production under capitalism: the teaching and valuation of achievement-

oriented action, the inculcation of respect for authority, technique improvement, the glorification of discipline, mortification of the body, and the belief in linear, unlimited progress. From this lens, sport possesses an obvious labour-capitalist material base, and for the New Marxists, sport becomes a place where participants rationalise, incorporate, and internalise labour-like behaviours. For them, in sports, participants are victims of a “false consciousness” that blinds them to the true nature of their activities and serves as a “training ground” for industrial productive activities. That is the reason why Brohm (1978: 76) maintained that sport “inculcates an attachment to the established order”. Or Murtry (1977: 11), who observed that sports:

not only mirror the social order in which they occur, but, more importantly, cause this order to be maintained intact by evangelising in popular form its essential structure of action.

In a sense, for them, sport is not only a mechanism of control and domination, but most importantly, sport is a form of labour that produces more labour, and thus perpetuates the values of capitalism.

However, the fact that sports hold a labour material base does not mean that sport is a form of labour. Morgan (1994), for example, argued that sport cannot be considered labour because this reveals a different kind of human activity. First, Morgan relies on Karl Marx, who defined labour as a “special productive activity” whose objective is to secure human survival. That is, labour produces things to satisfy human needs, and thus, the objects produced by labour forces are valuable because their goal is to satisfy demonstrable human needs. In other words, labour belongs to the realm of necessity. On the contrary, playing sports does not produce anything that satisfies human needs. In a sense, these are unnecessary activities that cannot be considered labour because their goals fall outside the realm of necessity. As Marx states in *The Capital*, “If the thing is useless, so is the labour contained in it; the labour does not count as labour, and therefore creates no value” (trans. 1977: 41).

To understand the differences between sport and labour, we need to consider the logic behind each. In the philosophy of sport, Bernard Suits’ (1978) idea of game-playing is widely accepted as a way to understand that sports belong to the sphere of play. Playing games and sports is, by definition, “the voluntary effort to overcome unnecessary obstacles”. The logic of sport falls out of the logic of labour since this relies on using the most efficient

means to satisfy human necessities. In labour, all possible obstacles that impede the achievement of certain ends are removed to maximise efficiency and productivity. Conversely, sport introduces unnecessary obstacles in the pursuit of useless goals. In other words, when participants enter sports activities, they subject themselves to unnecessarily demanding problems that demand doing something harder than it should be.

For instance, actions such as kicking a football into a net using only legs, as permitted by the rules, restrict the use of more efficient means, in favour of less efficient means to achieve a goal. In contrast, the rational capitalistic logic of labour would prioritise efficiency, favouring methods like using hands to complete the task. Or as Suits (1973: 53-54) put it, in labour activities, the introduction of unnecessary obstacles to the achievement of an end is regarded as an irrational thing to do, whereas in sports it is the essential thing to do. In short, sports cannot be considered labour because their logic places obstacles in the pursuit of useless goals that do not satisfy human needs – it inherently rejects maximum efficiency while embracing less efficient means to achieve an unnecessary and unproductive goal. The fact that sports do not belong in the realm of necessity, indeed, places them in the realm of freedom since, according to Marx, this:

begins only where labor which is determined by necessity and mundane considerations ceases; thus, in the very nature of things it lies beyond the sphere of actual material production (Marx, trans. 1967: 820).

The logic of sport reflects a distinctive approach to the kind of life modern societies push us to live, a social space where we are free of necessity and survival.

Although the characteristics of the apparatus of capitalist societies are present in sports, once these are inserted into the sportive arena, they are stripped away from their capitalistic logic (Morgan, 1985: 63) as we engage in the use of less efficient means to achieve goals that fall out of the realm of necessity. It is precisely the logic of sports that allows humans to enter another realm. This is the reason why Halak says that when we play sports, “we can transcend the determined boundaries of our being: we can free ourselves from the grip of our fate which dominates us”. Or Huizinga (1955:13), who noted that playing stands “quite consciously outside of ordinary life”, or Fink

(1957:21), who emphasised that play “interrupts the continuity and context of our course of life”.

However, even if the internal logic of sport cannot be considered labour, the insights of the New Marxists remain relevant as they identified that the material reality of modern sport is approached from a labour-like mindset. That means that, just like labour practices in the office or the factory, modern approaches to sports push and direct their participants toward maximum efficiency in the field of play. This entails that sports’ training methods, just like working processes in industrial-corporate societies, must be guided by specialisation, scientific worldview, and quantification and measurement of every possible action by the individual, aiming to enhance efficiency. In a way, in the industrial-corporate world, labour is guided by quantification, specialisation, scientific worldview, and efficiency, and these coexist in an interdependent circular relationship.

Given this relationship, then, the individual in the labour realm is confined to narrow, repetitive, and mechanical tasks, routine and monotonous activities, maximum coordinated movements, and rigorous adherence to strict protocols. This is why, for the New Marxists, modern working processes turn out to be alienated labour because “when the categories of function, efficiency, and output become central for identity, the result is alienation” (Meier, 1980: 29); the individual has become a tool for production. Under this realm, the worker rationalises every movement in their labour tasks, all to achieve maximum efficiency and productivity in the workplace – towards “mechanical efficient perfection”.

In capitalist industries, the highly mathematised and technologically driven labour processes dominate societies and individuals. Under these conditions, men “become a material that does not carry its laws of movement within itself but is dictated by the economy” (Vinnai, 1970). This is, for New Marxists, the triumph of what they called “instrumental rationality” – a mindset that focuses solely on the most efficient ways to achieve a goal, without considering the impact it might have on human beings. For them, the presence of “instrumental rationality” means the destruction of individuality and freedom since people are seen as mere objects rather than autonomous-creative beings worthy of respect (Inglist, 2004: 83). And this is the reason why the New Marxists maintain that society’s rules under capitalism are exploitative, unfair, immoral, and overall, they are a perversion of the human spirit (Guttmann,

p. 67). In their view, human personality, under this framework, is only an instrument for maximum production.

In the realm of sports, it is not an overstatement to say that modern sports are guided by a modern capitalist-industrial labour mindset. Today, numerous devices can be found in sports institutions that enhance these approaches to sport. For example, coaches and sports scientists use body composition analysers that describe the body in terms of water, fat, muscle mass, etc. Force platforms equipped with sensors detect biomechanical forces during athletic movements, generating data that is used to fine-tune performance and break records. Digitisers translate human motion into computer code, enabling precise analysis and simulation of athletic movements, which in turn are used by coaches to optimise training methods and techniques, and for athletes to maximise optimal performance. In recent years, artificial intelligence has further exacerbated this model by automating performance analysis and optimising training loads, pushing athletes even deeper into a regime of data-driven efficiency and control.

All these instruments foster a labour-like approach to modern sports. This is so because quantification, specialisation, scientific worldview, and efficiency are at the core of the contemporary conception of sports in its institutions. By bringing a labour-like mindset into the world of sports, much like in factories and offices, the training ground has become an arena where every movement and action of the athletes is meticulously measured and rationalised, all to achieve maximum efficiency in competition. In such a context, athletes find themselves constrained to narrow, repetitive, and mechanical tasks, engaging in routine activities that demand maximum coordination and adherence to strict protocols.

From this lens, there is no difference between the players and the office/factory workers since all of them are exercising their activities under practices that are subsumed under alienated modes of production. This is the reason why Laguillaumie (1972: 41) maintains that participants are “fabricated in the image of the worker and the track in the image of the factory”. The fact that the world of sports is subsumed in the realm of numbers and records, where specialisation is required, and consequently guided by a scientific worldview, all to achieve maximum efficiency, just as alienated labour, means the training field is a place where human movements become mechanical (Vinnai, 1970: 18). In short, and to put it more directly, just like the office

and the factory, the training field demands from individuals “mechanical efficient perfection”. It is no surprise that critics of sport maintain that in sports, participants find the same spirit, criteria, actions, and objectives that he or she finds in the office or the factory (Ellul, 2021: 384).

For that reason, Brohm (1976) famously claimed that sport, just like the workplace, has turned into a *prison of measured time* because the arena, where the spirit of play is supposed to reign, now mirrors corporations and factories, where individuals rationalise modes of production that would lead them to the alienation of their bodies. Under this framework, the athletic environment turns sports’ training methods into arenas of monotony where athletic movements and actions become habitual, repetitive, and tedious; athletes perform like machines, aiming to achieve the desired number through rationalised, perfect movements. Indeed, it is no coincidence that Guttmann described the obsessive pursuit of quantitative improvement in sport as “the beginning of evil”. For him, this drive inevitably leads to specialisation and a scientific worldview in which athletes are no longer seen as individuals, but are instead “metamorphosed into a cog in the machinery of sports”.

Perhaps some might argue that the fact that modern sport mirrors labour in factories and offices is not inherently problematic. They might contend that sport is safeguarded by its internal logic, and thus, the mechanised movements of athletes in sport can be acceptable. However, in the machinery of sport, human movements are mechanised, and individuals become “kind of” machines. This is a view that many agree is present in modern sports and argue against it because it has brought physical and mental punishment to the athletes.

Kretchmar (1994), Hoberman (1996), and, more recently, Aggerholm (2023) still emphasise that within this framework, athletes are subjected to physical punishment and are reduced to scientific objects rather than subjects with agency, feelings, and empathy. There is, in fact, substantial evidence that the primary forms of violence and abuse in sport – such as excessively intensive training, insufficient rest, corporal punishment, encouragement of “play hard” or “play hurt” attitudes, and excessive pressure (David, 2004; Gould, 2010; Smith, 2015; Coakley, 2017) – closely resemble the kinds of abuse observed in factories and workplaces. Just as in those environments, these practices often lead to loss of motivation, burnout, emotional stress, and eventually dropout – trends that have become increasingly visible

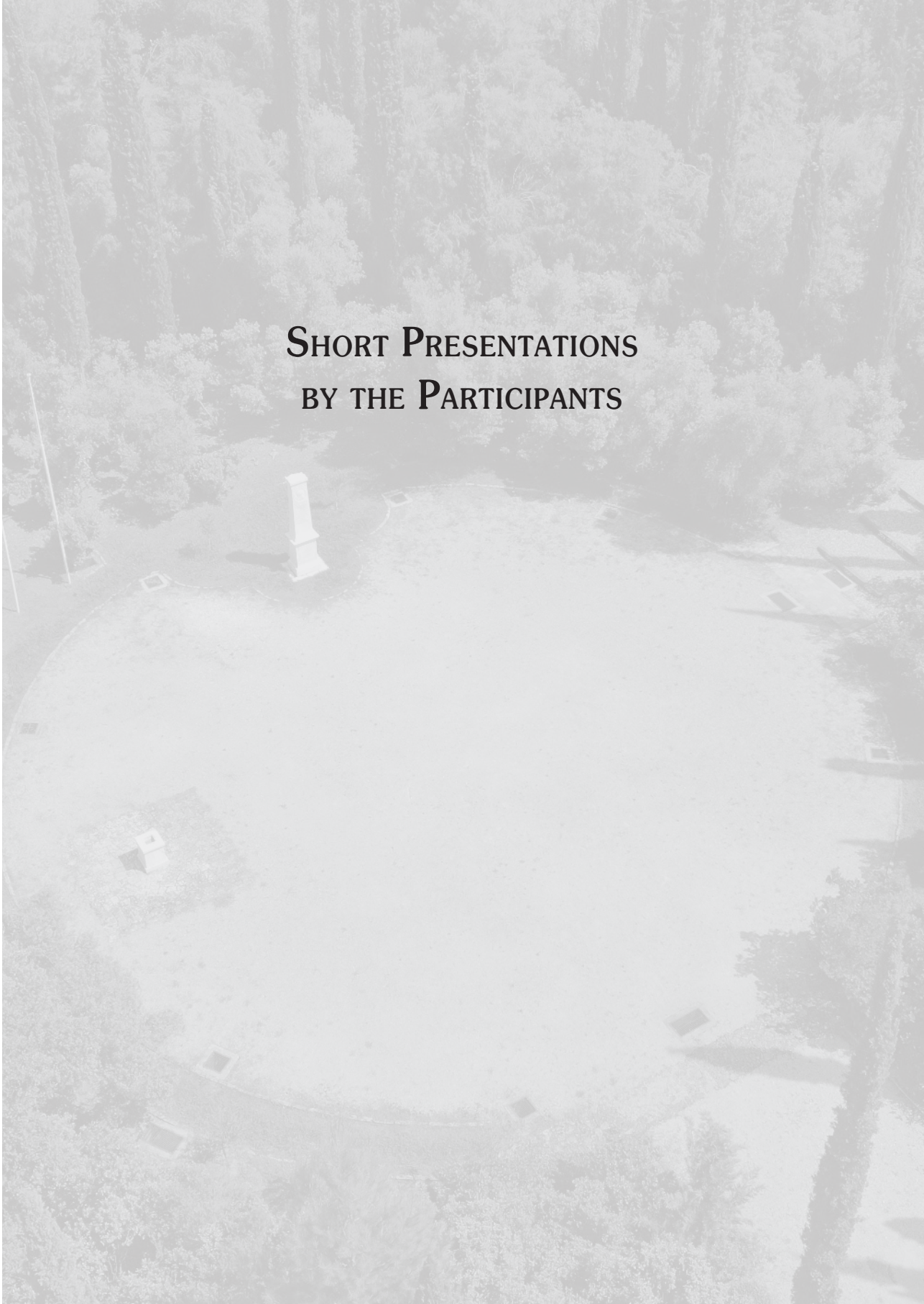
before, during, and after the Olympic Games, and which clearly conflict with Olympism's first fundamental principle. Although I am not proposing a strict causal relationship, I am suggesting that the prevalence of burnout and psychological distress among athletes is deeply intertwined with the labour-like logic that governs modern sport, which in turn originates from the obsessive pursuit of records and the excessive desire to quantify every possible athletic action within the sporting atmosphere. In other words, our most accepted, unquestionable, and deeply embedded approaches to Olympic sport in their institutions and universities are the ones that threaten Olympism.

If what I have said makes a little sense, I believe, first, that a reconsideration of the works of the New Marxist theorists may provide valuable insights for re-examining the current Olympic landscape, but also that sport within universities and academic institutions must try to recover its internal logic. This would entail studying sport from a Ludic standpoint, that is, from the internal elements that constitute sport, and not only from a scientific, therapeutic, or business-driven position, which are, I daresay, the reigning paradigms in which sport is usually studied (Twietmeyer, 2015). I believe that sport, as Weizsäcker (in Hoberman, 1996) says, "will be able to preserve its humanising influence and contribute to human dignity only if, as it develops, it resists this pressure, if it recognises its own inner laws". The fact that sport is now studied all over the world does not release it from the obligation to examine its own deepest premises.

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An aerial, grayscale photograph of a large, circular stone plaza in a park. A tall, white obelisk stands on the left side of the plaza. The plaza is surrounded by a dense forest of tall, thin trees. Several small, square stone markers are visible on the ground around the perimeter of the plaza. The text "SHORT PRESENTATIONS BY THE PARTICIPANTS" is centered over the image.

SHORT PRESENTATIONS BY THE PARTICIPANTS

A VALUES-BASED PROPOSITION FOR INTEGRITY IN ESPORTS

Aline LOPES DA SILVA CANDEO (GER)

Video game competitions have existed since the early 1980s (Jin, 2020). Their evolution followed technological developments, with arcade games evolving into online games and mobile games (Jin & Besombes, 2025). With the popularisation of high-speed internet, these competitions moved from person-to-person to the virtual sphere and, by the late 90s, such competitions were already referred to as "esports" (Borowy & Jin, 2013).

Then, in the 2020s, the COVID-19 pandemic and the inception of streaming services cemented the popularity of esports (Jin & Besombes, 2025). As most sports and non-sports competitions stopped due to the imposed restriction measures in the whole world, the gaming industry soared with the possibility of virtual competitions and decentralised broadcasting (Bousquet & Ertz, 2021).

Another factor of influence on the popularisation of esports is the fact that it is organised in a way that resembles sport, with components that allow for the measurement of performances and competition. This process is what Heere (2018) calls "sportification". Although this process has been anachronical across the industry, it reinforced the division of the roles of players and fans, even encouraging the development of partisan sentiments towards different esports "teams" with sports-like paraphernalia like team t-shirts and symbols (Välisalo et al., 2024). As a result, it is expected that esports competitions will have a following of 318 million people in 2025 (Statista, 2024).

This audience is estimated to be made of, mostly, male fans with an average age of 26 years (Välisalo et al., 2024). The popularisation of esports in a more "sportified" manner, especially among this young audience, did not escape the attention of sport governing bodies. Esports was included in the 2018 Asian Games as a demonstration event (Goh, 2023) and, most recently, the International Olympic Committee (IOC) announced the inception of its own "Esports Series".

The first edition of the “Olympic Esports Week” was promoted in 2023 and the inaugural Olympic Esports Games is scheduled to happen in 2027 (IOC, 2023b, 2025). Plus, the IOC has included a recommendation to “encourage the development of virtual sports and further engage with video gaming communities” in its 2020+5 agenda. There, the entity highlights the growth of the gaming industry despite the impacts of COVID-19 and how International Federations (IF) have promoted virtual forms of their sport to engage with the youth demographic (IOC, 2023a).

On the one hand the interest and engagement of the sports world in esports validated and, in parts, legitimised esports, and on the other hand the same interest has highlighted structural issues in esports. Those issues are generally connected to the fact that the esports industry is based on intellectual property. This means that the games belong to the companies responsible for developing and/or publishing them. And, in many cases, the publishers also control the organisation of tournaments for their game titles, including rules and codes of conduct. As a result, there is a lack of standardised rules and procedures across the industry.

As an attempt to remedy this, institutions that seek to legitimise and professionalise the esports structures have emerged. Those institutions either have the goal of unifying the governance of esports, like the International Esports Federation (IESF) and the World Esports Association (WESA), or aim to be the “guardian of the sporting integrity of esports”, like the Esports Integrity Coalition (ESIC).

This paper is more interested in the development and implementation of integrity regulations in esports. As ESIC discloses, they position themselves as guardians of the sporting integrity of esports. Thus, their starting point is sport integrity. For those reasons, henceforth notions of sport integrity will also be used to explore how a values-based proposition for integrity in esports would look. For this, it will propose that esports, as a game, have inherent values that constitute the ethos of esports, arguing that, currently, esports adopt an unsustainable perspective rooted in neoliberal perspectives that put emphasis on results and winning. Then, from ethical and moral perspectives, it will propose that integrity regulations should be aimed to protect these inherent values while promoting a safe and enjoyable space for gaming.

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FAIR PLAY PRINCIPLE IN ESPORTS

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Among the main elements of fair play, the ones most often mentioned are: respect for the rules and regulations, care for the integrity of sport, showing respect to rivals and avoiding achieving victory at all costs. Fair play, understood as respect for rivals and avoiding victory at all costs, is more difficult to realise in esports than in sport. This results from the fact that contact between players is digitally mediated. Hence, except for simple gestures and verbal communication, displaying respect towards a competitor during the game is made harder, and it is even more difficult to react spontaneously to this harm. Mutual respect in esports is certainly achievable, but it requires the competition to take place in a defined physical setting (using a local area network-LAN), for example, in a sports hall or a cultural centre.

Additionally, avoiding victory at all costs is difficult in esports, as activities directed at winning, realised with full technical, tactical and skill-related engagement, are justified as long as they result from the content of the game and are in accordance with the rules. It is, of course, possible to stop the game once the representation of the opponent stops being active. However, such an attitude can hardly be seen as an effect of gradation of a contestant's engagement in the course of the game. It can be at most seen as a borderline form of such gradation without taking into account intermediate levels.

Respect for rivals and avoiding victory at all costs are directly related to moral responsibility, the source of which is voluntary activity directed at the good of another human being (and other live beings). Hence, fair play, understood in that way, assumes a spontaneous reaction from a contestant himself or herself who consciously and rationally chooses the good of another

person and not their own good or that of some object or institution. The central value in this meaning is a human (other live beings) and the value is not immanently connected with sport, as it is rooted in common morality.

In esports we can speak first of all about the formal approach to fair play, as adherence to the rules and care for the integrity of sport. It should, however, be remembered that fair play understood in this way is criticised by many researchers as it is not connected with a spontaneous, voluntary reaction of a player but with teleological realisation of the arbitrarily imposed plan of the game. Consequently, not only players stand behind fair play but also a big group of people engaged in sport, from referees, to training teams, administration, the creators of games and fans. All of them are formally obliged to care for the highest quality of sporting competition. They can take care of this quality in many places directly and indirectly connected with that competition, e.g. in stadiums, game producing companies, politicians' offices, etc.

If one of the crucial roles of sport is social integration, esports does not yet fully realise such a function, as many esports games contest moral norms. Fair play has been applied to sport to show that a sporting show is a part of human culture in general and hence the moral norms operating therein should be subordinated to the social good. Sport therefore is supposed to be good for a human being and society, hence it should not only contribute towards the development of master sportspeople but also to social integration. When sport stops realising that function, it could be given up completely, since then its influence becomes harmful or even dangerous to society.

It should, however, be pointed out that shaping the moral stance of players through esports presents some basic difficulties. What we mean here is the moral controversies concerning the content of many games used in esports tournaments. Sport, at least in its institutionalised version, should affirm the values of common morality. Hence there is no place in sport for killing your opponents on purpose, torturing them, hurting them, limiting their freedom, etc. The rules of the game and refereeing in sport are supposed to eliminate all behaviours at odds with moral norms. Obviously, both death and pain can happen during a sporting competition, but only as a tragic accident and collateral damage of competition which is run in agreement with regulations (moral). Adhering to moral norms in sport does not only make sport responsible and just but also makes it an important factor bringing

society together. In this way, it constitutes a very good theoretical and practical basis for shaping the pro-social stances of citizens and is a desirable form of entertainment for spectators.

However, if the content of certain games used in esports tournaments is analysed, it turns out that the rules of those games assume contesting the norms of common morality. In such games as *Counter Strike: Global Offensive*, *Call of Duty: Warzone*, *League of Legends*, *World of Tanks*, you kill/murder a virtual opponent, or you destroy/devastate the existing order, often reminiscent of the order of the human world. Hence, formal responsibility and justice, at least in some esports, legitimise breaking fundamental moral norms. In other words, in esports an honest (moral) stance also assumes behaviour which is bad from the point of view of morality, as it imposes the duty to kill an opponent, destroy their belongings, etc.

Obviously, the creators of games keep convincing us that the harm is limited to the digital universe of the game, and not the reality as such, and therefore has no influence on the functioning of an individual in the physical world. Nevertheless, many researchers point out the possibility of a player getting addicted to the game or the identification of a player with his or her representations which can lead to serious health and social consequences.

Therefore, in esports it is possible to contest the moral norms in force in the physical world and it is not important that this happens directly in the universe of the game, as there is a possibility that certain of the protagonists' stances during the game are transferred to those of players existing in the physical world. From this point of view, fair play principles concerning formal responsibility and justice should also be considered, as, if in accordance with the rules (responsibly and in a just way) you can murder your opponent, a question must be asked as to what extent such behaviour is in agreement with the idea of fair play.

However, taking into account the enormous popularity of esports, especially among the youngest, an effort should be made to work out an axiological foundation of sorts for esports. It should comprise values that not only foster honest competition but, first of all, integrate society in moral, educational or formative terms. The fair play principle should be employed in constituting this foundation while remembering the limitations of this principle in esports.

Moreover, it should be considered which esports games should be chosen,

at least during official tournaments, for the sake of their content. The choice should be directed, first of all, by the adherence of attitudes and behaviour presented in games to moral norms observed in society. It will allow the avoidance of accusations of transferring or escalating aggression and violence from the digital universe of the game to the physical reality.

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THE EVOLUTION OF ONLINE GAMING INTO ESPORTS AT A NATIONAL LEVEL AND THE ROLE OF THE HELLENIC ESPORTS FEDERATION (H.E.S.F)

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Introduction

Esports refers to competitive gaming where athletes utilise electronic devices (keyboards, controllers, etc.) to compete in skill-based digital environments. Unlike traditional gaming, esports emphasises human vs. human competition rather than human vs. computer interactions. This study explores the historical evolution of online gaming into a global esports phenomenon, analysing factors such as financial incentives, accessibility, and massive online viewership. The research highlights the shift from casual entertainment to professional competition, emphasising Greece's institutional recognition of esports through the Hellenic Esports Federation (H.E.S.F.).

Methodology

A qualitative approach was employed, including interviews with industry professionals and analysis of academic literature. The study aimed to understand

1. Mr Fotios Maragkos participated in the Session and presented the paper.

esports' historical development, socio-economic impact, and potential integration into education.

Historical Overview

The origins of esports can be traced back to the 1980s with tournaments like the Space Invaders Championship. The internet's expansion in the 1990s and 2000s facilitated global competitions, leading to professional teams, streaming platforms (e.g., Twitch), and billion-dollar tournaments. Today, esports surpasses Hollywood in revenue, establishing itself as a dominant entertainment sector.

Hellenic Esports Federation (H.E.S.F.)

Recognised by Greece's Ministry of Education and Sports, H.E.S.F. is the official body for esports development, overseeing national teams and international representation.

Mission & Vision

H.E.S.F. promotes structured growth, fair play, and integrity in esports. Greece's Law 4908/2022 officially recognises esports, ensuring safety, transparency, and institutional legitimacy. The Federation envisions holistic athlete development, aligning with Olympic ideals while combating discrimination and cyber threats.

Esports and Education

Esports can enhance education by fostering teamwork, strategic thinking, and interest in STEM. Integrating esports into curricula could support digital literacy and career pathways in technology.

Social Impact

Esports provide an inclusive, gender-neutral competitive space. H.E.S.F. emphasises combating addiction, cyberbullying, and promoting digital responsibility.

Olympic Recognition

The IOC's inclusion of esports, with the first Esports Olympic Games set for 2027 in Riyadh, marks a historic milestone. Greece's national team victory in *Dota 2* (2024) underscores its rising influence.

Esports represent the natural evolution of sport in the digital era, blending cognitive skills with competition. Institutional maturation, akin to FIFA's formation in football, is underway. Resistance to esports' Olympic integration risks alienating 2.8 billion digital natives. Instead, embracing esports with scientific objectivity ensures the Olympics' cultural relevance.

Action Proposal

1. Educational Integration – UNESCO/ILO-backed programmes.
2. National Standards – "Digital Physical Education" in schools.
3. Global Collaboration – Ethical frameworks with institutions like MIT Sports Lab.

As Coubertin stated, "Sport is culture". Esports is the culture of the digital generation – worthy of recognition and pedagogical embrace. "sportified"

THE FUTURE OF SPORT: INTEGRATING TECHNOLOGY, INCLUSION, AND INNOVATION IN PHYSICAL EDUCATION

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1. The Impact of Technology on Enhancing the Learning Process in Physical Education Lessons for Medically Exempt Students

– An analysis of how interactive educational applications are transforming physical education classes into inclusive spaces, where students with medical exemptions can still learn, participate, and progress.

2. Smartphones, Smartwatches, and Body Analysis Scales – Digital Tools for Optimal Motor Density

– How can we leverage students' personal devices to measure, monitor, and stimulate physical activity, enhancing engagement and adjusting effort in real time?

3. Innovation in Equipment and Modern Infrastructure – Catalysts for Performance and Motivation

– From smart gyms to multisensory sports fields: how modern facilities and equipment contribute to the quality of physical education and to shaping the athletes of tomorrow.

In my research activity, I have focused on the impact of modern technologies on the didactic process of physical education lessons, with the main objective of integrating and supporting students with special educational needs or distinct physiological characteristics. The results of these studies have been presented in two international scientific papers, reflecting the practical application and real benefits of digital tools in the school environment.

The first paper, entitled *The Impact of Technology on Improving the Learning Process in Physical Education Lessons for Medically-Exempt Pupils*, published in Balneo and PRM Research Journal, Vol.14, No.2, 2023, pages 551–555, aimed to include medically exempt students in the educational process through the use of the digital application Info-Scutit-Sport. This application incorporates the entire physical education curriculum for middle school, transformed into 2,080 interactive questions with visual support (over 1,500 processed images). The study was conducted on a sample of 55 students, with an average age of 11.29 years, of whom 58.2% had a full exemption and 42.8% a partial exemption. Statistical analysis demonstrated a significant correlation between time spent in the application and improved academic performance: every additional 10 minutes spent on the application led to a 0.54% increase in performance. This method enabled the real and active inclusion of exempted students, contributing to their motivation and educational progress.

The second paper, *Monitoring the Effort Curve in Physical Education for Normal and Overweight Students Using Smartwatches and Mobile Applications*, published in the International Journal of Physical Education, Sports and Health (IJPESS), Vol. 2, No. 1, 2024, focused on real-time monitoring of students' physiological responses to effort through the use of smartwatches and mobile applications. The study analysed the effort curve based on body weight, distinguishing between students of normal weight and those who were overweight. By measuring variables such as heart rate and intensity of exertion, we were able to adapt the exercise levels to each student, avoiding overexertion and creating a balanced and motivating environment. Students became more engaged and aware of their own limits and progress, while the data collected provided teachers with a clear and objective overview of each participant's performance.

Through these two complementary research directions, I have demonstrated that technology can transform physical education classes into inclusive, adaptable, and evidence-based spaces. Whether concerning medically exempt students or students with varying physical abilities, the use of educational applications and

monitoring devices provides an effective framework for individualised progress, increased motivation, and enhanced performance. These initiatives confirm the essential role of technology in modernising education and promoting a student-centred approach.

Rhetorical Questions:

1. *Is it not a form of modern exclusion to reject technology in physical education, knowing that it represents the only bridge for students who cannot physically participate but are eager to learn and contribute?*

By refusing digital integration, we risk keeping physical education locked in a rigid format, missing the opportunity to transform every minute of class time into a real chance for development, even for those who appear "inactive".

2. *How ethical is it to demand efficiency and progress in a 50-minute physical education class without utilising the tools that help us understand, monitor, and personalise each student's effort?*

If time is limited and students are diverse, technology is no longer a luxury but a moral necessity for equitable and adapted education in line with each generation's realities.

Thanks to the findings from my study entitled *The Optimisation of Education through Feedback and Advanced Technology in Motor Learning and the Correction of Technical Sports Errors*, I can reinforce the argument that rejecting technology in physical education is not merely a didactic choice, but a decision with profound social and pedagogical implications.

This research clearly demonstrates that immediate audio-video feedback significantly impacts the reduction of technical errors in motor learning. If, within just a few training sessions, novice athletes (average age 10.5 years) corrected errors thanks to technology, how could we justify ignoring these tools in an educational system that has only 50 minutes per lesson to achieve complex learning objectives?

Thus, we can logically continue and challenge the sceptics:

3. *How can we demand technical performance and accuracy from students without providing them with the tools that have been scientifically proven to reduce errors, clarify movements, and stimulate learning?*

The link to my research is natural: whether dealing with medically exempt

students or overweight students, technology offers common, adaptive, corrective, and motivating language that has been scientifically validated.

Neglecting it means ignoring a vital lever for educational progress and equity.

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**OUR COMMON CULTURAL HERITAGE:
“HOME, AWAY FROM HOME: ἈΠΟΙΚΙΑ”
HONOURING THE HELLENIC CULTURE OF ASIA MINOR
FOR OLYMPISM AND PEACE**

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ABSTRACT

Μικρασιώτες (Mikrasiates) is the term for defining the Ἕλληνες (Hellenes) who lived in Asia Minor (Anatolia of today's Republic of Türkiye) from the 13th century BCE as a result of colonisation until the fall of the Ottoman Empire in 1923. The word “Greek” derived through Roman influence on the “mainland” and was accepted in most languages. Now, the word “Greek” means the people and culture related to the state with the internationally accepted name of “Greece”.

In modern Turkish, the word “Yunan” defines the “Ionian” people who were one of the four major tribes of Ancient Greece related to Asia Minor. They were the Hellenes (Greeks) who spoke the Ionian dialect. It has been suggested that the foundation of the Ionians was that they had a connection with Ion, son of a Pythian prince Xuthus who became the prince of the Peloponnese. When another Archaic Greek tribe, the Dorians, invaded the Peloponnese, the Ionians were first displaced to Attica, then to the coast of Asia Minor where they settled and founded the region of Ionia circa 1150 BCE. The idea of expanding came to practice during the Archaic Era (800 BCE-480 BCE) of Greek history. This idea is mostly referred to as “Greek Colonisation” and describes the way in which they started to spread across the Mediterranean, the sea of Marmara and the Black Sea.

Although the early period before Archaic Greek is usually considered as the “Dark Ages” in the history of Greeks, there is no doubt that without the *Mikrasiates* and their ambition to preserve their legacy, Hellenic Culture wouldn’t have been passed to the generations and geographies through the centuries. “Hellenism”, however, holds bigger meanings. From the ancient times, the language, culture, and values of the Hellenes has significantly impacted the world.

One of the aims of this article is to introduce the influence of colonisation in Asia Minor on promoting Panhellenism through philosophy, art and competitions (αγώνες/*agones*), considered as the cultural heritages of Greece and Turkiye. The other aim is to seek the answers to whether this knowledge holds the potential to promote Olympism and peace. The article’s time period is limited to the periods of the Ancient Olympic Games (Olympiad) from the beginning of the Archaic Era, 776 BCE, until the end of the Hellenistic Era, 146 BCE.

Keywords: Asia Minor, Hellenism, Olympism, peace, cultural heritage

THE DEVELOPMENT AND INTERNATIONAL EXCHANGE OF CHINESE ESPORTS CULTURE FROM THE PERSPECTIVE OF THE OLYMPIC SPIRIT – TAKING THE DIALOGUE PRACTICE BETWEEN CAPITAL UNIVERSITY OF PHYSICAL EDUCATION AND GREECE AS AN EXAMPLE

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Abstract

Against the backdrop of the vigorous development of the global esports industry, the integration of esports and the Olympic spirit has attracted much attention. Based on the development of esports in China and combined with the relevant practices of the Capital University of Physical Education, this paper discusses the achievements of the integration of esports and the Olympic spirit, and the models of international exchange, and proposes a direction for future development, aiming to provide a "Chinese solution" for the sustainable development of the global esports industry.

Keywords: Olympic spirit; esports culture; international exchange

1. Introduction: The Reconstruction of the Olympic Spirit in the Digital Age

With its digital and cross-regional characteristics, esports has become an important part of global youth culture. Its inclusion as an official event in the Asian Games and a demonstration event in the Paris Olympics marks the international recognition of its competitive attributes and cultural value, and is an extension of the Olympic spirit in the virtual field. Greece, as the birthplace of the Olympic

Movement, and China, as the world's largest esports market, carry out the theme exchange "Esports in the Olympics", which is of great significance to exploring the inheritance path of the Olympic spirit in the digital age.

2. The Development Status and Innovative Practices of Chinese Esports

2.1 The Two-Wheeled Drive of Industrial Scale and Policy Support

The number of esports users in China has reached 520 million, and the industrial income has exceeded 160 billion yuan. Event operation, content live broadcast and derivative development have become the core growth points. The State Council and local governments have issued policies to support the development of the esports industry, such as the "Esports Beijing" brand strategy. The Capital University of Physical Education has set up an esports major, built an integrated training system of "curriculum – training – certification", and cooperated with enterprises to enable students to improve their professional capabilities in practice.

2.2 The Collaborative Innovation of the Event System and Talent Training

Professional events such as LPL and KPL have formed a stable business ecosystem. University events such as the Beijing University Esports Super League have integrated the Olympic spirit into their operations and set up relevant awards. Talent training adopts the "three chains integration" model. The education chain works with enterprises to develop interdisciplinary courses. The industry chain allows students to participate in actual operation projects. The innovation chain promotes technological R&D to feedback teaching.

3. The In-depth Integration of the Olympic Spirit into Chinese Esports Culture

3.1 The fit of the Value Core: From the Arena to the Virtual Space

Esports players break through limits through training, reflecting the pursuit of "faster, higher, stronger". The live broadcast room of esports events has become a platform for dialogue among multiple cultures, promoting cross-cultural communication. In response to the chaos in the industry, regulations have been

issued and technical means have been used to ensure fair competition and build a governance system.

3.2 The Innovation of Cultural Expression: The Digital Translation of Traditional Elements

In esports activities, wushu and esports are cross-border displayed, and tai chi moves are integrated into the action design of game characters. There has been cooperation with the Palace Museum to develop game skins, restoring the aesthetics of intangible cultural heritage, and promoting the communication of cultural heritage to youth.

4. The Strategic Path and Implementation Framework of China-Greece Esports Cooperation

4.1 Cultural Integration: From Mythological Narrative to Digital IP

It is proposed to cooperate with Greece to develop a MOBA game with the Trojan War as the background and to integrate Chinese military strategy wisdom in the game and establish an innovation centre to be responsible for IP incubation. At the same time, it is proposed that an AR esports carnival be held at the Acropolis ruins to promote the integration of cultural tourism and esports. China can also hold similar activities at historical attractions.

4.2 Industrial Collaboration: Resource Complementary and Standard Co-construction

The establishment of a league between the esports leagues of the two countries' universities should be promoted, with a points mutual recognition and player exchange mechanism, and training bases. The two sides should jointly develop esports referee certification standards, combining China's physical fitness evaluation model and Greece's traditional sports referee training experience.

4.3 Educational Interconnection: Joint Talent Cultivation and Academic Dialogue

It is suggested that a master's double degree programme in "Esports and Olympic

Studies" should be developed, an esports education summit should be held and a white paper should be released. Also, "Esports + Olympics" general education courses should be promoted for Greek primary and secondary schools, and China should also improve its youth esports education system.

5. Conclusion and Prospect: Building a New Olympic Ecosystem in the Digital Age

China's esports has adopted the Olympic spirit and formed a culture which is aligned with it. In the future, Chinese universities and research institutions should build a global esports think tank, and release integration indices to lead academic research. The intensity of technology output should be increased, and technical equipment such as AI referee systems and VR training cabins should be promoted. By creating an "Esports Silk Road" and other means, Chinese traditional culture could be integrated into esports and cultural exchanges could be promoted. The Greek trip is an opportunity to show the soft power of Chinese esports culture, and China will continue to deepen international cooperation and contribute to the development of global sports culture.

MENTAL HEALTH AND PSYCHOLOGICAL TRAINING FOR ESPORTS ATHLETES

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Esports psychology is a branch of psychology that studies the psychological characteristics and patterns of individuals engaged in esports activities. It is also an emerging discipline within sports science. Research focuses include: the psychological characteristics of esports athletes, team behaviour in esports, psychological issues and coping strategies in esports training, foundational psychological skill training in esports, pre-competition psychological preparation, psychological regulation during esports competitions, and post-competition psychological recovery. These studies aim to promote the mental and physical health and performance of esports athletes, as well as to identify individuals with exceptional esports talent and competitive ability.

Mental health refers to the state where all aspects of the mind and its activities are in a good or normal condition. Esports athletes are influenced by various factors that can easily lead to issues affecting mental health, including emotional factors such as tension, anxiety, worry, and psychological burnout; cognitive factors such as mental baggage, perfectionism, and attribution of wins and losses; attention factors such as lack of focus and instability; and other factors such as diet, lifestyle, and sports injuries. If they are not subject to objective monitoring and effective intervention, the likelihood of developing severe psychological issues increases, which may hinder training outcomes and competitive performance.

A survey of 45 athletes from various popular esports disciplines revealed that 17 athletes exhibited significant stress, 18 athletes showed mild anxiety symptoms, 6 athletes had moderate anxiety, and 1 athlete was diagnosed with severe depression after seeking medical attention. To improve the mental health

of esports athletes, targeted psychological training is essential. The following will introduce three aspects: emotional calmness, mental clarity, and focused attention.

Firstly, how can esports athletes achieve emotional calmness? (1) Breathing regulation. Breathing regulation refers to a method of controlling emotions by adjusting the frequency, rhythm, depth, and manner of breathing. Breathing regulation is primarily used for relaxation. This method is convenient to implement as it is not restricted by time or space, and can be practiced either in group sessions or individually. For example, practicing in three stages – inhale (to lift the breath), hold (to stabilise the breath), exhale (to release the breath) – corresponding to 4 beats (or seconds), 7 beats (or seconds) and 8 beats (or seconds) can gradually improve breathing capacity and enhance the flexibility of transitioning between breathing rhythms. Basic procedure: In a quiet, well-ventilated environment with appropriate temperature and humidity, sit comfortably on a chair with armrests or lie flat on a bed with your eyes slightly closed. Mentally count the rhythm or duration of “inhale, hold, exhale.” As your ability improves, set higher goals. (2) Imagery regulation. Imagery regulation refers to the method of controlling emotions and behaviour through imagery. This is commonly referred to as “playing it back like a movie.” Content that can be visualised includes operational procedures, precautions, and successful experiences. The functions of imagery regulation include clarifying thoughts, focusing attention, relaxing the mind, and activating the body and mind. The clearer and more specific the imagery regulation, the better. (3) Suggestion regulation. Suggestion regulation refers to the method of controlling emotions and behaviour through verbal suggestions. Use positive and affirmative language to analyse opponents’ situations, formulate tactics, and guide the competition, replacing negative or questioning words: for example, “learn from opponents” instead of “fear opponents,” ‘relax’ instead of “don’t be nervous,” “focus on technical fundamentals” instead of “don’t allow mistakes,” and “I can complete the task” instead of “can I do it?” One must pay close attention to one’s gestures, posture, facial expressions, and eye contact, as these non-verbal cues are mediums for conveying suggestive content and may influence others’ psychology. Elite-level athletes typically establish 1-2 suggestive phrases tailored to their competitions. Some use them after each complete action, while others reserve them for critical moments.

Secondly, how do esports athletes achieve a clear mind? (1) Mindfulness. Mindfulness refers to a specific way of being aware – consciously noticing, living in the present moment, and refraining from judgment. It is a cyclical process

from “knowing” to “acting”. The purpose of mindfulness can be understood as the ability to be aware through intentional attention to the present moment and refraining from evaluating things. It has positive effects on an individual’s awareness, attention, and emotions. Specifically, athletes consciously perceive actions (such as the sensation of muscle tension) – unconditionally accept them mentally (such as accepting them as they are) – and continue to perform the current task (such as technical movements). Mindfulness has specific training methods, and interested athletes can listen to related recordings. (2) Reconstructing thoughts. This involves viewing difficulties, setbacks, and challenges from a new, positive perspective.

Furthermore, how can esports athletes achieve focused attention? (1) Mental orientation. Mental orientation refers to the direction of attention and the preparatory state of mental activity, i.e., directing conscious activity (the degree to which an individual is aware of and attentive to the external environment and oneself) toward a specific task. Only by selecting the correct direction of attention can limited mental resources be concentrated and allocated to specified activities. Psychological orientation theory has been elevated in the field of sports. It is one of the core components of sports psychology. Athletes should direct their attention toward controllable factors, namely themselves, the present moment, and the action process. (2) Attention training. During training and competitions, athletes perceive stimuli through visual, auditory, and imaginative mental activities; stimuli can be set as targets for sustained attention for a certain period. As stability improves, the duration can be gradually extended, and attention control capabilities will also be enhanced. Distractions may occur during practice, but athletes must promptly adjust and return their attention to the target. After achieving better attention effects in quiet environments, introduce distracting stimuli or competitive environments to enhance focus across various scenarios.

In summary, psychological training should adhere to the following principles: integration with specific sports disciplines, differentiated treatment, balance between comprehensiveness and focus, self-motivation, long-term systematic approach, evaluative assessment, and transferability. It should follow the process of “building confidence, initial evaluation, team implementation, individual consultation, facilitating integration, monitoring progress, and final assessment.” Attention should always be paid to the athlete’s process accumulation, ability development, and behavioural improvement.

Keywords: esports psychology; athletes; mental health; psychological training

THE CURRENT SITUATION: PROBLEMS AND TALENT CULTIVATION PATH OF ESPORTS COMMENTARY IN CHINA

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1. Research Objectives

Esports is an emerging sport, and there has been ongoing debate in the industry about whether it qualifies as a sport. Against the backdrop of the globalisation of the internet, the esports industry is developing rapidly and attracting increasing attention from society. Commentators play a crucial role in the dissemination of esports culture, and esports commentators exhibit new characteristics distinct from those of traditional sports commentators. At the same time, there are many problems in esports commentary, such as its excessive entertainment orientation, "internet celebrity" tendencies, poor language expression skills, and uneven commentator quality. This study aims to analyse the current situation and existing problems of esports commentary in China and to propose suggestions for the development of future esports commentators.

2. Research Methods

Literature Review: Information related to esports commentary was collected through internet searches and relevant written materials.

Case Study: A case study was conducted on esports commentary during important esports events to investigate the current status of esports commentary.

Expert Interview: Interviews were conducted with sports commentators,

esports industry professionals, and scholars to understand their views on the current status and development strategies of esports commentary.

3. Research Results

Esports commentary and traditional sports commentary share similarities in terms of explaining, describing, and commenting on the games, but there are also many essential differences. In terms of dissemination methods, traditional sports commentary mainly relies on radio and television for dissemination, but esports commentary, as a relatively new sports event, is more dependent on the Internet. Esports has not yet been widely recognised as a mainstream sports event, and the Chinese government's attitude towards the live streaming and cultural dissemination of esports commentary has gone through a long process from non-support to tolerance and then to support. Therefore, the dissemination channels of esports competitions and their commentaries are mainly concentrated on new media platforms. In terms of commentary content, traditional sports commentary often varies due to the characteristics of different sports, making it difficult for commentators to comment on multiple sports, resulting in more commentators becoming specialised in certain specific sports. However, the content of different types of esports competitions is often highly similar, mostly requiring the same sense of tension. The requirements for commentary are basically high-pitched, fast-paced, energetic, and with a distinct personal style. For instance, commentators who now comment on *League of Legends* and *Honor of Kings* competitions often used to comment on *DOTA2* competitions. In terms of audience coverage, most esports enthusiasts are relatively young. According to the following research, it can be seen that people clearly prefer humorous, witty, and distinctive commentators with clear personal styles and good looks, and they pay more attention to the entertainment value of the commentary.

The esports commentary industry has a large market demand, a wide variety of commentary events, and diversified commentary platforms. Esports commentators are highly dependent on their fans, have strong entertainment value, diverse commentary types (knowledge-based commentary, entertainment-based commentary, passionate commentary), and a wide range of sources. The characteristics of esports commentary are also reflected in the use of network language, the reliance on camera perspectives for commentary, the high difficulty

of commentary work, the main reliance on the Internet for commentary, and the distinct personalities of esports commentators.

Compared to the international level, the esports commentary industry in China is still relatively immature. Esports commentary has a bright future in the eyes of many people, but it is undeniable that there are many problems at present. 1. There is no established system for the live streaming and broadcasting of esports competitions. People cannot watch any esports events on authoritative TV stations or sports channels, but can only watch them through authorised online live streaming platforms and app software. Therefore, esports commentary has not yet gained a position in mainstream media. 2. Esports commentators lack professionalism. The entry threshold for the esports commentary industry is low, esports commentators are overly "internet-famous", and their qualities vary greatly. 3. There are serious language expression problems in esports commentary. The speaking speed is too fast, emotions are too intense, vulgar language and internet slang are frequently used and subjective perspectives are used to forcibly cover up the game situation.

4. Research Suggestions

The suggestions are mainly analysed from the perspective of talent cultivation for esports commentators. The Electronic Sports major of Capital University of Physical Education and Sports is the best in China, ranking first. I teach the course Esports Hosting and Commentating to students and have the following thoughts: 1. Improve the selection and training mechanism for esports commentators. Strengthen the training of in-service sports commentators; other universities should set up esports commentary majors or directions and select elites through commentator competitions for training; 2. Enhance the professional qualities of esports commentators. Improve language expression ability, enhance on-site response ability, improve esports professional ability, enhance moral and psychological quality, and establish personalised and brandised reputation; 3. Commentary training can be divided into three stages, gradually improving. The first stage is the "tape recorder" style commentary. Be familiar with the details of a specific esports game, follow the screen closely during commentary, say what is seen, be accurate in correspondence with the screen, and speak fluently. Make all necessary preparations. The second stage is to be a "mover of the scene",

seeing what others cannot see. Utilise the data mastered to connect the scene and the audience, becoming a bridge between the two, enriching the players' sense of presence, immersion, and understanding. The third stage is to be a partner commentator, with a clear division of labour. One can speak freely and even provide "soulful commentary". Esports commentary is usually done by two to three people, jointly completing the commentary work. In a combination of two esports commentators, one usually takes on the role of describing the screen, and the other provides comments and analysis. In a three-person combination, a chief commentator is usually set up to coordinate the speaking opportunities of the other two and have an overall grasp of the situation, inserting and filling in as needed, and being flexible and mobile. An important function of the chief commentator is to handle situations such as sudden blackouts of the commentary screen or when the commentary partner speaks very little.

In China, there is a very special major called Broadcasting and Hosting Art, which is specifically for training broadcasters and hosts. The elites all graduate from Communication University of China. They have clear pronunciation, pleasant voices, and good images, which give them a natural advantage in esports commentary. It is believed that with the approaching first Esports Olympic Games in 2027, the esports market will develop further and further, and the demand for esports commentators will continue to rise. Commentators with good foreign language skills will have a larger stage to showcase their talents. We look forward to more outstanding esports commentators joining this industry and promoting the continuous development of the professionalism of esports commentary.

A BRIEF DISCUSSION ON ESPORTS AND ITS INTEGRATED DEVELOPMENT WITH OLYMPIC CULTURE

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Abstract

Esports originated from video games and was initially regarded as a form of sporting subculture. With the rapid advancement of digital technologies, particularly artificial intelligence, esports has evolved into a global cultural phenomenon and is now officially recognised as a sport by the International Olympic Committee (IOC). Esports has transformed public perceptions of traditional sports and expanded the spatial and temporal boundaries of sport. To better integrate esports into the Olympic Movement, it is necessary to guide its development with Olympic cultural values, leverage its educational and cultural functions, and promote harmonious development between individuals and society.

Keywords: esports, developmental transformation, Olympic culture, integrated development

1. The Evolution of Esports: From Subculture to Mainstream Culture

1.1 Esports Originating from Video Games

Esports evolved alongside the development of video games and is defined as "competitive, organized video gameplay using information technology as its

primary tool".^[1] In its early stages, the legitimacy of esports as a sport was highly contested, relegating it to the status of a sporting subculture. The main points of scholarly debate included: (1) unlike traditional sports, esports does not primarily rely on physical abilities but is predominantly intelligence-driven; (2) esports does not depend on physical sports venues or facilities; and (3) its competitive nature alone does not suffice to define it as sport.^[2]

Moreover, esports has faced criticism for its potential adverse effects on the physical and mental health of young people. Physically, extended training may lead to prolonged sedentary behaviour, declining eyesight, hand injuries, and sleep disturbances. Psychologically, risks include gaming addiction, anxiety, and social withdrawal. From a longer-term developmental perspective, uncritical pursuit of esports can result in one-sided personal development. Its typically young and short professional career span can also leave youth uncertain about their future after retirement. Additionally, the emerging industry's inherent developmental uncertainties may negatively impact individual trajectories.

1.2 Esports as an Official Sport

Esports is a product of the information age. In 2017, the IOC's official recognition of esports sparked a wave of "esports mainstreaming" in China, significantly reshaping public perceptions of sport. At present, over 10 comprehensive universities and sports-specialised institutions in China – including the Communication University of China and Capital University of Physical Education and Sports – have established esports programmes. These programmes systematically train students in the fundamental theories and methods of the esports field. By building esports training platforms, inviting international experts, and organising student participation in external competitions, these programmes broaden students' horizons and enhance professional competencies.

Additionally, since the establishment of China's first esports-themed town in Hangzhou during the Asian Games, similar towns have emerged across various provinces and cities. Their business scope covers esports event operations, programme production, club management, and peripheral development. Traditional sports clubs have invested in esports, and well-known companies have sponsored elite esports projects, providing essential economic support for sustainable development.

However, relying solely on state-level policy guarantees and economic support

is insufficient to ensure the long-term integration of esports into China's Olympic sphere or the broader international Olympic Movement. Notably, esports' educational and cultural values remain underdeveloped. Addressing these potential challenges requires identifying the cultural commonalities between esports and Olympic culture and using core Olympic values to guide esports' development.

2. Integrating Esports with Olympic Culture

2.1 Event Selection and Alignment with Olympic Values

When selecting esports disciplines, the IOC must prioritise their alignment with Olympic values. For example, sports simulation games such as FIFA, NBA 2K, and Gran Turismo and virtual sports like Zwift (cycling) or VR rowing leverage virtual simulation technologies to enable more sports enthusiasts to experience the joy of exercise. Virtual Taekwondo, for instance, uses VR technology and safety measures to give fans who previously could only watch the sport the chance to actively participate in competitive settings. This enhances inclusivity by letting more people experience the authentic atmosphere of competitive sport. ^[3]

Conversely, games featuring violence or gambling elements—such as CS:GO and League of Legends—should be excluded, as they fail to embody the Olympic spirit of friendship, solidarity, and fair competition and may subtly harm young people's psychological well-being. Such selection criteria also indirectly regulate the development of esports titles themselves: any game aspiring to Olympic inclusion must embody the Olympic ethos.

2.2 Virtual Worlds Reshaping Modes of Olympic Participation

At its core, Olympism promotes sport as a way of life to foster harmonious human development. The new Olympic motto also emphasises uniting humanity through sport, underscoring the vital relationship between sport and social solidarity inherent in Olympic cultural values.

In the post-pandemic era, social atomisation has become increasingly pronounced. Esports can help rebuild interpersonal connections in both virtual and real-world contexts. First, team-based games require frequent voice communication among participants, fostering temporary emotional resonance.

Research indicates that 76% of participants maintain social contact after matches (ESA 2022 report). Second, because esports players are often geographically dispersed, interacting via virtual avatars can reduce appearance-related anxieties, especially for those with social fears, making it easier for them to forge social ties through online platforms. Finally, esports can strengthen intergenerational connections—for example, fathers and sons or fathers and daughters teaming up to play esports together can create new channels of dialogue, deepen mutual understanding, and promote harmonious intergenerational relationships.

3. Conclusion

As an emerging Olympic sport, esports has advanced global exchanges and the integration of sporting cultures. As a virtual form of sport, esports should integrate with traditional forms to jointly support the Olympic Movement. By harnessing diverse sporting modalities to serve human harmonious development, esports and traditional sport together can help build a society committed to safeguarding human dignity and peace.

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RESEARCH ON STRATEGIES FOR PROMOTING THE CONSTRUCTION OF BEIJING AS A “TRIPLE OLYMPIC CITY” THROUGH ESPORTS

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Basis for Topic Selection

In August 2024, the State Council issued “Opinions on Promoting High-Quality Development of Service Consumption”, putting forward support for the development of industries such as esports. In March 2025, the General Office of the CPC Central Committee and the General Office of the State Council issued the “Special Action Plan for Boosting Consumption”, which clearly proposed a desire to “promote the consumption of animation, games, esports, and their related derivatives”. In June 2025, the Beijing Municipal Publicity Department and 11 other departments jointly issued “Interim Measures on Supporting the High-Quality Development of the Game and Esports Industry in Beijing”, with the goal of enhancing Beijing’s competitiveness in the gaming and esports sector through stronger policy guidance and support.

In recent years, esports has emerged as a new type of competitive sport with tremendous potential for industrial innovation and significant social and cultural value. Characterised by its diverse attributes spanning sports, technology, and culture, esports is regarded as a vehicle for global cultural exchange, a bond connecting young people emotionally, and a new driver of regional economic growth. The strategic significance of esports has been continuously rising, with the strategy being successively incorporated into the Asian Games and the Olympic Games.

At present, Beijing is capitalising on its “Four Centres” strategic positioning and the advantages of being a “Dual Olympic City”. Supported by a thriving sports consumption market, there is now a widespread consensus on empowering urban development through sporting events. However, Beijing’s sporting events currently face certain development bottlenecks, primarily manifested in the homogenisation of events and insufficient efforts in developing emerging sports competitions. Esports is expected to become a key breakthrough for Beijing to capitalise on its “Dual Olympic” legacy, overcome the current development bottlenecks of sporting events, and secure a leading position in the future sports industry.

Significance of the Research

(1) Based on an analysis of the current state of esports events in Beijing, the issue of insufficient esports event resources will be thoroughly examined by integrating trends in the integration of esports with culture, commerce, tourism, and sports, as well as leveraging Beijing’s “Dual Olympic City” advantages. This approach aims to fully demonstrate the development potential and the necessity for future expansion.

(2) With regard to the context of the upcoming inaugural Esports Olympic Games in 2027, this study emphasises virtual sports by analysing their advantages, future market value, and significance within the Esports Olympic Games and comparing these factors with the current relative gap in the field of virtual sports. The research fully demonstrates the necessity and urgency for Beijing to establish a presence in the virtual sports industry.

Research Value

(1) This study explores ways to strengthen the planning and development of esports events in Beijing and enhance the utilisation of “Dual Olympic” venues, providing decision-making references for accelerating the construction of Beijing as an international capital of sports through an “esports pathway”.

(2) This study investigates development pathways for Beijing to accelerate the deployment of virtual sports, systematically identify feasible measures, and

provide constructive and forward-thinking recommendations for Beijing's pursuit of becoming a "Triple Olympic City".

Research Methods

An in-depth analysis of the current state of esports events in Beijing is conducted using multiple research methods, including literature review, case analysis, and logical reasoning to reveal existing problems and shortcomings in the current development of esports events in Beijing. By referencing domestic and international development experiences and integrating Beijing's unique resource endowments, the study puts forward practical solutions and suggestions for further development.

Research Findings

The study reveals that there are still several problems and shortcomings in the current development of esports events in Beijing:

(1) Insufficient high-end esports event resources: According to the "2024 China Esports Industry Report", Beijing accounted for only 6.5% of the nation's offline esports events in 2024, far behind Shanghai (17.8%) and Chengdu (15.3%). With its transportation advantages and abundant large-scale venues, Beijing has become a preferred city for offline esports spectators, especially those from the northern regions. However, the current number of high-end esports events in Beijing does not match the strong spectator demand and rich venue resources, suggesting ample potential for future development. In November 2024, the *Honor of Kings* KPL Annual Grand Final was held at the Workers' Stadium, attracting over 30,000 spectators onsite, with cross-province and cross-city attendees accounting for 82% of the total. The event generated direct economic benefits of approximately 303 million Yuan, including about 234 million Yuan contributed to the six key sectors of tourism. This fully demonstrates the powerful attraction of high-end esports events to enthusiasts across China, and their positive impact on promoting local cultural tourism and regional economic development.

(2) The development and layout of emerging events such as virtual sports continue to lag behind. At present, the broad definition of esports encompasses traditional esports, virtual sports, and simulated sports. Virtual sports share

a similar philosophy with traditional sports, as both offer equivalent sports values, demand significant energy expenditure involving large muscle groups, and operate under similar rule systems. The advantages of virtual sports lie in their ability to transcend the limitations of time and space, providing athletes with a safer, more cost-effective, and convenient environment for training and competition. Thus, the development of traditional sports is empowered, offering a new approach to promoting nationwide fitness, and holding significant potential for future market expansion. With the inaugural Esports Olympic Games set to be held in 2027, virtual sports, as a key area in esports exploration by the International Olympic Committee, will become a core competition event at the Esports Olympics. Currently, Beijing's approach to the development of virtual sports events is neither systematic nor sufficiently in-depth, with certain lag in both awareness and industry development. This is reflected in several aspects: (1) insufficient awareness among stakeholders regarding the necessity and urgency of developing virtual sports, and an underdeveloped policy support system, (2) inadequate supporting infrastructure, such as a lack of professional virtual sports venues and training bases, (3) underdeveloped industrial ecosystem, with weaknesses or gaps in areas such as talent cultivation, software and hardware research and development, equipment manufacturing, and event operations related to virtual sports.

Research Conclusions

(1) Strengthening the layout of high-level esports events can be achieved by coordinating the use of Beijing's large sports venue resources and supporting the introduction of major tournaments. Firstly, emphasis should be placed on attracting global top-tier tournaments such as the League of Legends World Championship, the Counter-Strike Major Championships, and the VALORANT Champions Tour: Masters. Taking the hosting of the 2025 Honor of Kings KPL Annual Grand Final at the National Stadium ("Bird's Nest") as an example; Beijing can establish a high-end benchmark of "major tournaments + Dual Olympic venues" and shape the city's image as the "Capital of International Esports Events". The vertical structure of esports events in the city will be enhanced by capitalising on Beijing's unique resource endowments to cultivate local tournament brands such as the Beijing Collegiate Esports Super League.

(2) Accelerating the development and layout of virtual sports events and taking the lead in pilot initiatives will accumulate valuable experience. Relevant government departments are advised to support the development of virtual sports through measures such as financial subsidies and the establishment of industry guidance funds. Support should be provided for hosting influential virtual sports events including the inaugural China Virtual Sports Open Finals and the 2025 Beijing Digital and Intelligent Sports Open. Districts, universities, and communities should be encouraged to hold diverse virtual sports experience events, community tournaments, and collegiate competition to reduce entry barriers and raise public awareness. Active communication with the General Administration of Sport of China and the Chinese Olympic Committee is encouraged to apply for hosting national team training camps, official test events, and warm-up matches for the inaugural Esports Olympic Games. Applications should be submitted to the International Olympic Committee to host international qualifying and preliminary rounds for the inaugural Esports Olympic Games, thereby gaining experience in organising and operating international virtual sports events.

(3) By actively engaging in securing virtual sports authorisations and developing relevant standards, Beijing can seize early opportunities for development. It is recommended that, with unified coordination of the municipal government and leadership from the Municipal Sports Bureau in collaboration with relevant departments of the General Administration of Sport of China, applications can be submitted to the International Olympic Committee and relevant international sports federations for the exclusive domestic operational rights, event hosting rights, and related digital content copyrights for ten virtual sports disciplines: archery, baseball, chess, cycling, sports dance, motor racing, sailing, shooting, taekwondo, and tennis. This would position Beijing with a strategic advantage in the core content resources of virtual sports. Upon successful application, collaboration with the General Administration of Sport of China and other relevant departments should be established to formulate standards and certification systems for virtual sports events, grant authorisation to host virtual sports competitions and create a vast market space for virtual sports.

(4) The virtual sports development ecosystem will be improved by promoting talent cultivation, industrial clustering, and supporting infrastructure construction. Support should be given to Capital University of Physical Education and Sports in leveraging its distinctive positioning as the “Beijing International Olympic Academy” to enhance the development of esports sports and management

programmes. Taking the “China-Saudi Arabia Year of Culture” as an opportunity, esports industry talent exchange and cooperation programmes with Saudi Arabia can be developed to cultivate high-quality, international sports professionals in line with the requirements of the Esports Olympic Games. Support for the development of virtual sports industry clusters should prioritise attracting enterprises in three main categories: hardware research and manufacturing, software and platform development, and event operation and content production, thereby establishing a complete industry chain. Efforts should be made to strengthen infrastructure and supporting facilities including the construction of professional virtual sports competition venues, training bases, research laboratories, and public experience and education centres. Support should also be provided for the adaptation of existing Olympic venues, large stadiums, and public sports facilities for virtual sports or to incorporate experience spaces. Beijing’s virtual sports development ecosystem should be improved across all stages, including industry, academia, research, and practical application.

Through the combined implementation of these initiatives and the strengthened development of esports events and virtual sports, new momentum will be stimulated for Beijing’s digital economy and a new identity for the city will be created. Such initiatives will lay a solid industrial foundation for future applications to host the Esport Olympic Games, making a pioneering contribution to the city’s journey toward becoming a “Triple Olympic City”.

CONCLUSIONS OF THE WORKING GROUPS



WORKING GROUP 1

This document summarises the findings of an exploratory discussion among non-specialist participants regarding the evolving relationship between artificial intelligence (AI), esports, and the Olympic Movement. The aim was not to reach a full consensus, but rather to identify and present a combination of favourable and unfavourable considerations to inform future decision-making.

The discussion acknowledged that AI and esports are undeniable parts of our current reality and have already significantly impacted sports, from the evolution of training and refereeing tools to how audiences consume and perceive sports.

Key takeaways regarding AI include:

- **Challenges:** Significant concerns were raised about engaging youth in sport given modern tools, the moral and ethical use of AI (specifically data control, privacy, the imperative need for regulations, and cybersecurity risks for stored data), and the sustainability implications of powerful computing. Educational challenges also surfaced, including students' over-dependency on AI, ensuring critical thinking in Olympic education, and the need for better training for educators on responsible AI use.

- **Opportunities:** AI is seen as beneficial for preserving Olympic history and values, enhancing stakeholder experiences (e.g., athlete-centred training), and improving fairness in sports refereeing through tools like HawkEye and VAR, thereby fostering Olympic values during competition.

Key takeaways regarding esports include:

- **Challenges:** Fundamental challenges include defining "esports" and establishing criteria for inclusion/exclusion of titles, issues of intellectual property and accessibility (platforms, internet connection), and the current fractured

structures of esports, and the need for harmonious regulations and clear organisational responsibilities.

- **Opportunities:** Despite these challenges, the inner values of the esports community (respect, friendship, togetherness, excellence) are akin to Olympic values, presenting a strong opportunity for their promotion. Esports can also offer increased accessibility and diversity for competitors and serve as a valuable vehicle to engage kids and young people in sport practice. The potential for coexistence and knowledge transfer between esports and "traditional" sports was also highlighted.

Ultimately, the group's discussions converged on the central question, *"How can we include AI and esports in programmes that already exist—including education—including children, local communities, and national governing bodies of each sport?"* The prevailing sentiment was that both AI and esports should be viewed as tools, and the primary challenge lies in effectively assimilating these tools into existing programmes to weave Olympic values into daily life, especially during non-Olympic periods.

This exercise has generated more questions than answers. The group is aware of this and supports the exploratory emphasis of our work on the voyage of discovery in the growing relationship between AI, esports and the Olympic Movement. It is important to emphasise that none of the participants would declare themselves a specialist in either AI or esports, so the debate was guided by the general knowledge among us. With different lived experiences and backgrounds, the group did not arrive at a consensus. Rather, the result of the discussion is a combination of favourable and not so favourable considerations. In turn, it would be desirable to see the points made here considered in future decision-making processes involving the three topics.

It is undeniable that artificial intelligence and esports are part of our current reality and cannot be ignored. In fact, when thinking about the application of technologies connected to both topics in the Olympic Games, it is possible to say that they have been part of the evolution and development of training and refereeing tools that are part of sports. They have also impacted on the way that the audience consumes sports before, during, and after Olympic Games. In other words, they have changed the way that people in general perceive sports. This produces challenges that go way beyond playing fields and affect directly, for example, how educators apply pedagogical methodologies. A relevant worry detected during conversations was how the modern tools have changed the

relationship of kids and teenagers with sports, posing it as a challenge engaging these communities in sport practice.

This challenge also meets a few others, for one, the moral and ethical use of artificial intelligence in sport. Computers are fed with great amounts of data and people should have control of whether they agree or not that they are used. The uses of data should, also, be aligned with Olympic values. This is to say that, for example, such tools should respect personal autonomies. Following that, it is imperative for regulations that establish boundaries and clear definitions of what those tools are used for to be introduced (again, for example, security and vigilance that invades personal privacy are divided by a thin line). The possibilities to explore uses of names, images, and likeness are becoming diverse and unregulated. Because of this, a valid worry is related to how and who would store this data, and this goes from audiences to athletes. As the world becomes data-driven, certain types of data become a target for cyberattacks and it is a duty of those that collect it for their own purposes to ensure its protection. The whole setup requires potent computers to process big data and powerful servers to store it, and this requires great use of power. In an era where sustainability is of special concern so that we can provide the future generations with the same opportunity to enjoy the environment for personal development, including sports, the responsible use of artificial intelligence must also be considered.

The specific challenges for educators did not go unnoticed. With a cohort of professionals from education, questions and worries regarding the challenges in adopting artificial intelligence for educational purposes were extensively debated. The over-dependency and reliance of students on artificial intelligence produces uneasiness. The thinking is, then, extended to how artificial intelligence should be applied for Olympic education, especially if it would also allow space for critical thinking and personal reflection on how Olympic values are relevant for daily life. Plus, and just as relevant, comes the question of whether educators are ready and well informed enough to guide students on the responsible use of the many different AI-based tools available. For this, it is necessary to have more training coming from professionals that are truly aware of how such tools should and should not be used.

That is to say that not everything is bad. There are instances where the use of artificial intelligence is perceived as positive. Technology can, for one, help in preserving the history of the Olympic Games so that the promotion of the Olympic values can be done in a more holistic way. As we mentioned before, it

is undeniable that technology is currently part of the Olympic Movement. The uses related to artificial intelligence can – and should – be executed to enhance the experiences of stakeholders, for example, training that has an athlete-centred philosophy on using data for more assertiveness rather than following a “no pain, no gain” logic. For athletes, coaches, referees, and spectators the application of artificial intelligence in sports refereeing can help in diminishing human error with technologies like HawkEye and VAR. These are allies in increasing the perception of fairness of sports, which is very beneficial to fostering Olympic values during competition. In sum, society in general has been enjoying the spoils and booms of the current use of artificial intelligence. What remains to be determined is what is the best way for it to be applied and should it be used indiscriminately or, alternatively, what needs to be enhanced? The use of critical thinking for this is fundamental and this is the type of knowledge that global governing institutions (in this case, of sports) have a duty to promote and foster.

Now, the looming interest of the said global governing institutions of sports in esports has also contributed to the debate about the concept of esports and whether they would carry Olympic values. Once again, it was clear among the group that if esports were to be fully included in the Olympic Movement, it would represent a whole new set of challenges. The first one is posed as a fundamental challenge: what is exactly the concept of esports? What titles would be included, and which ones would be excluded? What would the criteria for this be? When looking at these questions, it became clear that the motives for such an inclusion would also have to be clear, as well as the implications of such an inclusion. Video games are products based on intellectual properties; the same goes for the fact that they need a specific platform to be played on (consoles, computers and/or mobile phones). With this comes the issue of accessibility. Such games and consoles might not be available to all, or there could be technical difficulties with poor internet connections, for example. Plus, during the discussions and panels it became clear that the current structures of esports are fractured, and the inclusion and further expansion of esports would require harmonious regulations. The question remains as to who would be responsible for such organisations.

Yet, on the other hand, this also means that there are existing structures that can be explored. The esports community, aware of its issues, has its own inner values. Based on competition, they do celebrate values akin to Olympic values. Respect, friendship, togetherness, and excellence are also necessary in esports. For this reason, it is fair to consider it as an opportunity for promoting

Olympic values, especially because it may also mean an opportunity for increased accessibility and diversity of people competing together. From this perspective, it is important to point out that esports and “traditional” sports can coexist, as they do right now. And with it, it is relevant to consider bringing stakeholders from the esports sector closer to the sports sector. The knowledge transfer between one and another (in both directions) is something that would be desirable for both sides, especially on how esports can be a vehicle to engage kids and youth to also practice sport.

This feeling led the group to develop one question that sums up the general feeling of the discussions held during the two days after attending presentations from professionals from academia. The question is as follows: *How can we include AI and esports in programmes that already exist – including education – including children, local communities, and national governing bodies of each sport?*

As we see, the real challenges lie in how both of those tools – as it seems that one consensus from the group is that both artificial intelligence and esports in this context are tools – would be assimilated by existing programmes. This is especially relevant when considering what happens when the Olympic Games are not happening. To promote full engagement, Olympic values should be woven into the fabric of daily life, and for such, it is fundamental that every actor knows their role.

WORKING GROUP 2: EKECHEIRIA

Olympic Games, AI, and Esports

Question 1: How can AI contribute to the Olympic Games and their values?

Main Contributions of AI to the Olympic Movement:

Athlete Performance Enhancement:

- Analyses biomechanics, heart rate, sleep, and nutrition
- Tools like Strava recommend rest periods, injury prevention

Scouting & Talent Identification:

- AI processes video & performance data to identify talent
- Increases accessibility and diversity in sport

Skill Learning & Coaching Support:

- Provides real-time feedback to athletes
- Enhances technique through motion analysis

Fair Play & Refereeing:

- AI helps referees with accurate decisions (e.g., VAR)
- Detects doping patterns and cheating

Broadcasting & Fan Engagement:

- Personalises viewing experiences

- AI curates highlights and immersive content

Sustainability & Inclusivity:

- Aids in resource planning for sustainable Olympics
- Ensures inclusivity through data-driven policy

Ethical Concerns:

- Must remain a tool, not a decision-maker
- Risks include dehumanisation, misinformation, and bias
- Importance of preserving human judgment and values

Question 2: Is esports a sport and does it align with Olympic values?

Arguments Supporting Esports as a Sport:

- Requires strategic thinking, coordination, training
- Shares preparation and discipline like traditional sports
- Played under fair and structured competition rules
- Involves full mental and sometimes physical exertion

Challenges in Alignment with Olympic Values:

- **Health:** Sedentary lifestyle, screen time, short career spans
- **Respect:** Lack of physical presence affects mutual respect development
- **Equality:** Access to high-end equipment/internet creates unfair advantage
- **Friendship:** Online communities more isolated than traditional sports

Suggestions for Alignment:

- Conduct events offline under equal conditions
- Enforce ethical codes and fair play in esports federations
- Promote inclusion, discipline, and respect through design & regulation

Conclusion:

- Esports is evolving and can embody Olympic values

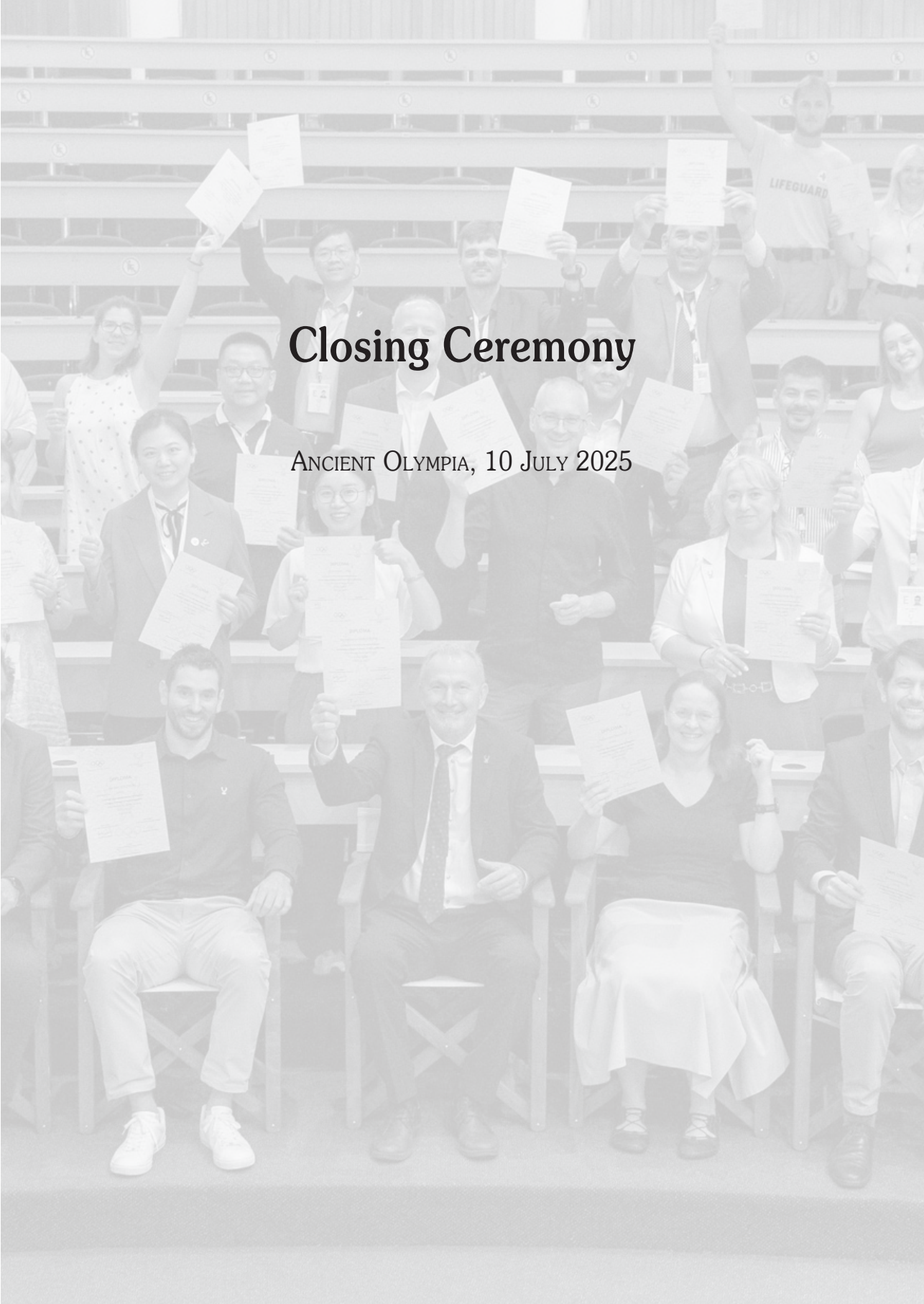
- Still faces challenges in health, respect, and equality
- Recognition depends on regulation, culture, and community buy-in

Side aspect:

Esports Player Perspective: Are they athletes?

Physiological & Mental Demands:

- High-intensity training schedules (mental + physical)
- Use of coaches, psychologists, nutritionists, physiotherapists
- Tournament duration often spans multiple hours (e.g., 7-hour finals)
- Physical conditioning improves mental performance – many clubs now require fitness

A grayscale photograph of a group of approximately 20 people, mostly men, seated in stadium-style bleachers. They are all smiling and holding up white certificates or diplomas. The certificates feature the Olympic rings logo and some text. In the background, a man in a white t-shirt with 'LIFEGUARD' written on it is visible. The overall atmosphere is celebratory.

Closing Ceremony

ANCIENT OLYMPIA, 10 JULY 2025

ADDRESS
on behalf of the Session Participants
by Candeo Aline LOPES DA SILVA (GER)

I would like to start by thanking the International Olympic Academy — and all the staff members — for promoting and organising the present Session. I think I speak on behalf of all my colleagues in expressing how the past days have been rich in discussions and debates. Each one of us will take something home after this.

I would also like to thank all of my colleagues who were part of this Session. We had an incredibly diverse group coming from different backgrounds and from all over the world. We held respectful debates, shared conversations and created bonds here. I hope that, in line with the central theme of the Session, we can keep in touch with each other, even if virtually. But it would also not hurt if our paths cross again in the future and that from here some collaborations emerge.

Last, but not least, I would like to thank all of the presenters who came here to share a part of their knowledge and who were kind enough to let us pick their brains a little bit, both inside and outside of the Sessions. Professors Kostas, Jim, Irena, Adam, Andreas, Rafael, Cem, Emmanouil, Raoni, and Yoav, thank you for giving all of that and, also, for all the chats in-between the Sessions. I am sure we have all appreciated your availability and kindness.

ADDRESS
on behalf of the Working Group Coordinators
by LJ VAN ZYL (RSA)

Good afternoon, IOA Dean, President, Staff, and Participants,

Let me begin by expressing my deepest gratitude to the President of the International Olympic Academy and the Dean for their inspiring leadership and for making this unique gathering possible. Your vision and dedication set the tone for everything we have experienced here.

I also want to extend my heartfelt thanks to the IOA staff for the incredibly warm welcome you have given me on this beautiful campus. From the moment I arrived, your kindness, guidance, and attention to detail made me feel not only comfortable but truly valued.

A special word of thanks goes to the medical staff for their constant support and care. Knowing that we are in such capable hands has given all of us great peace of mind throughout our stay.

To the lecturers, thank you for sharing your wisdom, your passion, and your stories. Your Sessions have inspired us deeply and reminded us of the values and ideals that unite the Olympic Movement.

And to my fellow participants, thank you for opening your hearts and making me feel at home. Arriving here as a solo traveller, all the way from South Africa and knowing no one, could have been intimidating. Instead, because of you, I felt like I was immediately part of a family, and I know I have made lifelong friends here.

Walking around this Academy, the outstanding sport facilities, the lively dining hall, and even wearing the accreditation cards, as I told a friend last night, I truly got that Olympic Games feeling again. It brought back powerful memories of my own journey as an athlete, representing my country in Beijing 2008, London 2012, and Rio de Janeiro 2016. For a moment, it felt as though I had stepped back into that world of unity, excellence, and inspiration.

As this unforgettable chapter comes to a close, I want to wish all of you, IOA President, Dean, staff, lecturers, and participants, a safe journey back to your homes and countries. May we all stay connected and continue to carry forward the Olympic spirit we have shared here.

Thank you once again for making me feel like part of the IOA family.

Safe travel, and let us keep in touch.

Thank you.

ADDRESS
on behalf of the Session Lecturers
by Assoc. Prof. Adam TOTH (IRL)

It is my honour, on behalf of all the lecturers, to thank President Tsolakis, Professor Georgiadis, Dr Karatsolis, Marilena and all who are part of the International Olympic Academy, for facilitating a fantastic 15th International Session for Educators of Higher Institutes of Physical Education. The lectures, working group Sessions and discussions all sparked fantastic debate on a broad range of topics – in particular, the practical and ethical implications of various digital technologies within sport, esports and the Olympic Movement.

I would also like to thank all the participants for their active engagement and thoughtful questions throughout the conference. It's always wonderful to attend and contribute to conferences that bring together individuals who vary in their academic, geographical and cultural backgrounds, as these kinds of conferences foster the development of new perspectives that facilitate the generation of better questions that address future scientific and educational endeavours.

Thank you all again and congratulations to the International Olympic Academy on hosting a very fruitful and successful 15th International Session for Educators of Higher Institutes of Physical Education.

CLOSING ADDRESS
of the Session Proceedings
by the Dean of the International Olympic Academy
Prof. Konstantinos GEORGIADIS

The International Session for Educators has been established as an IOA think tank for sport and Olympism during the last 50 years.

New concepts, like the concept of Olympic education, were created and supported scientifically by fellow professors.

We realised through discussions that technological evolution is accompanied by concerns in regard to the social, educational and humanistic role of sport.

The lecturers explored the interplay between technology, particularly artificial intelligence (AI) and esports, and their implications within the Olympic Movement.

The presenters discussed the potential of AI in education to foster a more inclusive and ethically grounded learning environment.

They examined the challenges that esports face in integrating with the traditional Olympic values.

Additionally, they addressed the emergence of performance-enhancing technologies like neurostimulation in sport.

They also analysed the evolution of electronic games as a cultural phenomenon and finally emphasised the need for ethical considerations and innovation in aligning these modern developments with the values of sport and Olympism.

The integration of esports into the Olympic Movement raises questions about governance and alignment with Olympism.

AI can revolutionise education by promoting inclusivity and ethical development.

Philosophy and historical research need to accompany the technological evolution and its outcomes.

Finally, since the Session is concluded, I would like to thank the lecturers, the coordinators, all the participants and the IOA staff.

A grayscale photograph of many national flags flying on tall poles against a background of trees. The flags are arranged in a row, and the text "List of Participants" is overlaid in the center.

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